

Facilitator Guide

Parents and Carers · Primary

SESSION 1	SESSION 2	SESSION 3	SESSION 4	SESSION 5	SESSION 6
---------------------	---------------------	---------------------	---------------------	---------------------	---------------------

One page for every slide. Each page shows the slide, what it is for, what to do and say, the activity and how long to spend.

Workshop day 9:30 - 2:30 · Timings are indicative

How to use this guide

The guide follows the six slide decks exactly. Every visible slide has its own page, in deck order, so you can keep the guide open beside the presenter view and turn one page per slide.

Each session opens with a planning page: the intent, what participants will leave with, what to prepare, and a run sheet with clock times.

EVERY SLIDE PAGE HAS

Header strip	The session colour, the session name and the slide number in the deck.
Slide and facts	A picture of the slide, the suggested minutes, the running clock, the grouping, and the Workbook page if there is one.
Purpose	One line on why the slide is there.
What to do	Numbered steps, in order.
Key messages	What participants should take from the slide.
You might say	Wording you can use or adapt, where the team has written it.
Activity card	Format, grouping, time, the prompt, steps, how to bring the room back and how to close.
Keep in mind	Cautions and what to avoid.
Background and thread	Context for you, and how the slide links to other sessions.

SESSION COLOURS

Each session keeps the colour used in the Workbook, so the page a participant has open matches the colour on your page.

The day at a glance

Time	Session		Slides	Page
9:30 - 10:15	1	Supporting your Autistic child to flourish	18 slides	p. 6
10:15 - 11:00	2	Understanding Autistic Experience: Sensory and Thinking	23 slides	p. 25
11:00 - 11:15		<i>Morning tea</i>		
11:15 - 12:15	3	Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity	20 slides	p. 49
12:15 - 12:45		<i>Lunch</i>		
12:45 - 1:30	4	Home and Community	13 slides	p. 70
1:30 - 2:10	5	Partnership with the School	14 slides	p. 84
2:10 - 2:30	6	Full Circle	7 slides	p. 99

The thread through the day

Participants are parents and carers. They keep their own child in mind all day. A few Workbook pages carry forward:

- Session 1: What I love and value about my child (returned to in Session 6).
- Sessions 2 and 3: sensory, thinking, communication and capacity, always linked back to their own child.
- Session 4: their child's signs and what helps, planning an outing, and what works at home.
- Session 5: Prepare for a conversation with school (brought to Session 6).
- Session 6: Three small things: one to try at home, one for school, one strength to name.

Ways of working

- Parents and carers are the experts on their own child. Invite their knowledge; never lecture.
- Some families are going through a very hard time. Keep it warm, never blaming, and let people pass.
- Keep other families' stories in the room. Discuss situations, not identifiable children, staff or schools.
- Every activity has an option to pass. Participants may move, write, listen or step out as they need.
- Look at the environment, routine and demands before asking a child to change. Include strengths, interests and joy.
- Participants write in their Workbook. Nothing in it needs to be shared.

Before the day

- ☐ Workbooks and pens for every participant, and tables set for pair and small-group work.

SESSION 1 · SUPPORTING YOUR AUTISTIC CHILD TO FLOURISH

- ☐ Local Traditional Custodians name confirmed and Acknowledgement of Country prepared in your own words.
- ☐ Young people's voices video tested with sound, captions on and transcript available.
- ☐ Venue details for housekeeping: exits, facilities, quiet space, breaks and evaluation arrangements.

SESSION 2 · UNDERSTANDING AUTISTIC EXPERIENCE: SENSORY AND THINKING

- ☐ Overwhelm and sensory joy video clips cued and tested with sound and captions.
- ☐ Autistic thinking video clip cued (once sourced).

SESSION 3 · COMMUNICATION, CONNECTION AND MANAGING DAILY CAPACITY

- ☐ Purple, blue and orange Post-it notes on each table, and wall or board space for notes grouped by colour.
- ☐ Three videos tested with sound: Communication experiences (slide 5), Being social (slide 11) and Masking (slide 17).
- ☐ Edited captions switched on and transcripts available for each video.
- ☐ Slide 20 closing script read through beforehand so it can be delivered slowly.
- ☐ Lunch arrangements confirmed so the close on slide 20 is not rushed.

SESSION 4 · HOME AND COMMUNITY

- ☐ A visible timer for the 6-minute and 8-minute table activities.
- ☐ Quiet space available: burnout and School Can't may be raised and some parents may need a moment.
- ☐ Information ready on where families can find further support, to give at a break if someone raises a current crisis.

SESSION 5 · PARTNERSHIP WITH THE SCHOOL

- ☐ Sticky notes and pens on every table; butcher's paper on the wall headed Home, School and Solutions.
- ☐ Student voice video (Adon) tested with sound, captions on and transcript available.
- ☐ Copies or a clear view of the Partnership tools shown on slide 11.
- ☐ The NCCD Meetings Tool Kit link (<https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>) and the Department of Education plain-language guides for families.
- ☐ Helpline numbers on slide 13 (Autism Connect, Disability Gateway, Carer Gateway, Lifeline, Kids Helpline) checked as current.
- ☐ A quiet option for participants who find the power discussion difficult.

SESSION 6 · FULL CIRCLE

- ☐ Titles and dates for the family webinars and deep dives, once confirmed (slide 4 shows "Titles and dates to confirm").
- ☐ Link and QR code for the online Community of Practice, once available (slide 4 shows "Link and QR code TBA").
- ☐ The feedback link (TBA) and QR code added to slide 6 and tested; paper or verbal alternative available.
- ☐ Local follow-up and contact arrangements confirmed.
- ☐ Protected time: at least 4 minutes for feedback.

SESSION

1

9:30 - 10:15 · 45 MINUTES · 18 SLIDES

Supporting your Autistic child to flourish

SESSION INTENT

Welcome parents and carers, establish an accessible way of working together and begin with each child as a whole person. Participants are positioned as the experts on their child, hear from Autistic young people and are introduced to a neurodiversity-affirming frame, fluctuating capacity and flourishing.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Name three things they love or value about their child as a reference point for the day.
- Understand the language used in the workshop and the value of following their child's lead.
- Describe neurodiversity, neurodivergence and a neurodiversity-affirming approach in their own words.
- Recognise autism as a dynamic disability, where capacity can change across the day, week and term.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
9:30 - 9:35	Opening and acknowledgements	1-4	5
9:35 - 9:44	Welcome, housekeeping and introductions	5-7	9
9:44 - 9:48	Workshop overview and language	8-9	4
9:48 - 9:55	Your child and your knowledge	10-11	7
9:55 - 10:04	Young people's voices	12-13	9
10:04 - 10:11	Neurodiversity and the whole child	14-16	7
10:11 - 10:15	Dynamic disability, joy and flourishing	17-18	4

PREPARE

- ☐ Local Traditional Custodians name confirmed and Acknowledgement of Country prepared in your own words.
- ☐ Young people's voices video tested with sound, captions on and transcript available.
- ☐ Participant Workbooks and pens for every participant.
- ☐ Venue details for housekeeping: exits, facilities, quiet space, breaks and evaluation arrangements.
- ☐ Tables set for small-group sharing.



Parents and Carers Workshop

Primary · Supporting your Autistic child to flourish

Parents and Carers Workshop - Supporting your Autistic child to flourish

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

9:30 - 9:31

Open the day and name the workshop focus for parents and carers.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Have the title slide on screen as participants arrive and settle.
- 2 Welcome participants and introduce the facilitation team.
- 3 Name the day as a chance to build shared language, look closely at your own child and leave with some practical next steps.
- 4 Frame the day around understanding and support, not fixing children or making them appear less Autistic.
- 5 Keep this opening brief so introductions and the first reflection have enough time.

KEY MESSAGES

- The day is about understanding Autistic experience and helping children and families flourish.
- Everything today adds to what parents and carers already know about their child.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some families arrive after a hard morning or a hard term. A warm, unhurried welcome matters more than starting exactly on time.

Acknowledgement of Country



Acknowledgement of Country

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:31 - 9:33

Acknowledge the Traditional Custodians of the land on which the workshop is taking place.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Deliver the Acknowledgement of Country in your own words, following organisational protocol.
- 2 Name the Traditional Custodians of the land where the workshop is being held, where this has been confirmed.
- 3 Allow a brief pause before moving on.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not read a generic script you have not prepared; take time before the day to learn the local Country and custodians.
- Keep the Acknowledgement respectful and unhurried, even if the session is running late.



Statement of reconciliation

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

9:33 - 9:34

Share the organisation's commitment to reconciliation.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Share the organisation's statement of reconciliation as provided, following organisational protocol.
- 2 Move on without adding commentary or discussion.

YOU MIGHT SAY

We at Positive Partnerships value and recognise the diversity of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander cultures and heritage and their proud part in Australia's national identity. We acknowledge and continue to learn about Australia's colonial past and the historic and ongoing impacts on Australia's First Nations people. We believe in and strongly support the Truth-telling of Australia's colonial history and in moving forward as a nation we must encourage open, honest dialogue and build relationships built on respect and trust.

First Nations people are advised that this workshop may contain images and voices of people who are no longer with us.

First Nations advisory

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

9:34 - 9:35

Advise First Nations participants that the workshop may contain images and voices of people who are no longer with us.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the advisory aloud or leave it on screen long enough for everyone to read it.
- 2 Move on without further comment.

Everyone is welcome at this workshop. We want you to feel that it is ok to be authentically yourself.

Please let us know if there is anything we can do that helps to include you in the workshop.

Everyone is welcome to use their own strategies to help them engage and to participate effectively.



Everyone is welcome

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:35 - 9:37

Set an inclusive tone and invite participants to engage in whatever way works for them.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read or paraphrase the welcome: everyone is welcome to be authentically themselves and to use their own strategies to engage.
- 2 Let participants know they can move, stand, step out, fidget, write, listen or pass at any time.
- 3 Invite participants to let the team know, at any point in the day, if there is anything that would help include them.
- 4 Acknowledge that some parents and carers in the room may be Autistic or neurodivergent themselves, and that this is welcome too.

KEY MESSAGES

- Different ways of participating are welcome.
- Participants can ask for what they need at any time.

Housekeeping



Tea / Coffee



Exits



Facilities



Phones



No Smoking / Vaping



Personal Needs



Questions



Workbook



Other Information



Evaluation

Housekeeping

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:37 - 9:39

Cover the practical arrangements for the venue and the day.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Cover tea and coffee, exits, facilities, phones, no smoking or vaping, personal needs, questions, the workbook, other local information and evaluation arrangements.
- 2 Point out any quiet or low-sensory space available at the venue.
- 3 Explain how and when questions can be asked, including in writing or privately at a break.
- 4 Let participants know they can keep their phone on if they need to be contactable by their child's school or carer.

Introductions

At your table, introduce yourselves briefly to each other.

Who you are

Your name, and who you are here for.

Your child or children

Their age or year level, if you would like to share it.

One thing

What would you like to know by the end of the day?

Introductions

SUGGESTED TIME

5 min

CLOCK

9:39 - 9:44

GROUPING

Table groups

WORKBOOK

Workbook - One thing I would like to know today

Help participants meet the people at their table and think about what they hope to take from the day.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce yourself briefly, then hand over to the tables.
- 2 Invite brief introductions at each table: each person shares their name, the child or children they are here for (age or year level if they would like to), and one thing they would like to know by the end of the day.

KEY MESSAGES

- Participants bring useful knowledge and many different experiences.
- Meeting other parents and carers is part of the day.

ACTIVITY

Table introductions table groups · 4 minutes

Your name, the child or children you are here for, and one thing you would like to know by the end of the day.

- 1 Introduce yourself briefly, then hand over to the tables.
- 2 Give tables about 3 minutes to introduce themselves.

Close: Invite participants to note their one thing in the Workbook.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not ask about diagnosis, school or family circumstances. Some parents may share a lot quickly; thank them warmly and offer to talk more at the break.
- Keep introductions at the tables so everyone gets a turn in the time.

Thread Participants can look back at their one thing in Session 6 (Full Circle).

Workshop overview

9:30 - 10:15	Session 1 · Supporting your Autistic child to flourish
10:15 - 11:00	Session 2 · Understanding Autistic experience: sensory and thinking
11:00 - 11:15	Morning tea
11:15 - 12:15	Session 3 · Communication, connection and managing daily capacity
12:15 - 12:45	Lunch
12:45 - 1:30	Session 4 · Home and community
1:30 - 2:10	Session 5 · Partnership with the school
2:10 - 2:30	Session 6 · Full circle

Workshop overview

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:44 - 9:46

Orient participants to the shape of the day.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the six sessions and the breaks on the slide without turning it into a detailed agenda.
- 2 Point out Morning Tea at 11:00 - 11:15 and Lunch at 12:15 - 12:45.
- 3 Explain that the morning builds understanding of Autistic experience and the afternoon moves to home, community and partnership with the school.
- 4 Let participants know that timings are indicative.

KEY MESSAGES

- The six sessions form one connected day.
- The day moves from understanding your child to practical steps at home, in the community and with school.

Language and autism

Words matter, and people have different preferences.

Identity-first

Many Autistic people prefer "Autistic person". Autism is part of who they are.

Person-first

Some people prefer "person on the autism spectrum". That choice is theirs.

Follow their lead

Use the words your child and your family are comfortable with.

Today we use identity-first language, and we respect every preference.

Language and autism

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:46 - 9:48

Introduce the language used in the workshop and respect for each person's own preference.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that the workshop uses identity-first language, such as "Autistic child", because many Autistic people prefer it.
- 2 Acknowledge that some people prefer person-first language, such as "person on the autism spectrum", and that this choice is theirs.
- 3 Encourage parents and carers to follow their child's lead and use the words their child and family are comfortable with.
- 4 Keep this practical and brief; avoid turning it into a debate about one correct term.

KEY MESSAGES

- Words matter, and people have different preferences.
- The workshop uses identity-first language and respects every preference.
- A person's own language for themselves should be respected.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some parents may still be getting used to the word "autism" for their child. Reassure them there is no test on language today.

Discussion activity

What are some things you love or value about your child?

- 1 Think of three things that make them who they are: strengths, joys, interests, connections.
- 2 Write them in your workbook. Not needs or challenges, just who they are.
- 3 Share one with the people at your table, if you would like to.

Discussion activity - What do you love or value about your child?

SUGGESTED TIME

5 min

CLOCK

9:48 - 9:53

GROUPING

On your own, then tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - What I love and value about my child

Begin the day with the child as a whole person: strengths, joys, interests and connections.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to think about their child and write three things that make them who they are.
- 2 Offer examples: strengths, joys, interests, connections, things that make them laugh.
- 3 Ask them to leave needs and challenges aside for now; there will be time for those later.
- 4 Give quiet thinking and writing time before inviting sharing at tables.
- 5 Keep sharing voluntary.

KEY MESSAGES

- The day starts with the child as a whole person, not with a list of needs or challenges.
- Strengths, interests and joy stay part of every later conversation.

ACTIVITY

Private reflection with optional table sharing on your own, then tables · 5 minutes

What are some things you love or value about your child?

- 1 Invite participants to write three things in their workbook.
- 2 Give two or three minutes of quiet writing time.
- 3 Invite participants to share one with their table if they would like to.

Close: Ask participants to keep this page handy and to keep this child in mind for the rest of the day.

KEEP IN MIND

- For some parents this is hard to do in a difficult season. If someone is stuck, suggest one small moment from the last week that they enjoyed.

Thread The child held in mind here is the reference point for Sessions 2 to 6, and returns in Session 6 when participants name one strength to share with their child.

Parent and carer experience

You know your child

Today builds on what you already know about your child with shared language, useful ideas and practical tools.

Your experience matters

Your knowledge and experiences are welcome here.

A partnership

You are the expert on your child. We bring information about neurodiversity-affirming practice to talk through together.

Parent and carer experience

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

9:53 - 9:55

Position parents and carers as experts on their child and as partners in the day.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Acknowledge that participants know their child in ways no one else does.
- 2 Explain that the day adds shared language, useful ideas and practical tools to that knowledge.
- 3 Frame the day as a partnership: parents bring knowledge of their child, the team brings information about neurodiversity-affirming practice, and we talk it through together.

KEY MESSAGES

- You are the expert on your child.
- Your knowledge and experiences are welcome here.
- Today builds on what you already know.



Young people's voices



Young people's voices

SUGGESTED TIME

5 min

CLOCK

9:55 - 10:00

Make space for Autistic young people to be heard in their own words.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the video as a chance to listen to Autistic young people directly, not to compare them with your own child.
- 2 Make sure captions are on and a transcript is available.
- 3 Play the video without interrupting.
- 4 Allow a short pause when the video ends before moving on.

KEY MESSAGES

- Young people's voices belong in the decisions and supports that affect them.
- Each young person's account is their own; no single account speaks for every Autistic child.

What did you notice?

- What stayed with you?
- What would you like to understand more deeply about your child?

What did you notice?

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

10:00 - 10:04

GROUPING

On your own, then whole room

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Young people's voices**Support reflection on the young people's voices and link it to participants' own child.****WHAT TO DO**

- 1 Invite brief private reflection on the questions on screen before any discussion.
- 2 Invite observations grounded in what the young people said.
- 3 Ask what participants would like to understand more deeply about their own child.
- 4 Record a few recurring words or questions on the board without forcing agreement.

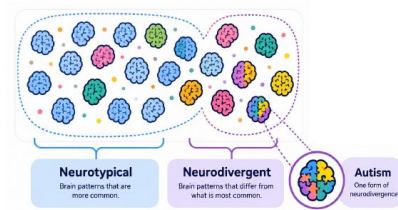
ACTIVITY**Think, write and optional share** on your own, then whole room · 4 minutes**What stayed with you? What would you like to understand more deeply about your child?**

- 1 Give a minute of quiet thinking or writing time.
- 2 Invite a few optional contributions from the room.

Close: Link the questions to the sensory, thinking and communication content that follows.**KEEP IN MIND**

- A young person's words can bring up strong feelings for parents. Acknowledge this simply and keep sharing optional.

Neurodiversity and neurodivergence



Neurodiversity is the whole picture.

Neurotypical and neurodivergent describe brain patterns within neurodiversity.

Autism is one expression of that diversity.

Neurodiversity and neurodivergence

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:04 - 10:06

Introduce the language of neurodiversity, neurodivergence and autism.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that neurodiversity is the whole picture and includes everyone.
- 2 Name neurotypical and neurodivergent as brain patterns within neurodiversity.
- 3 Name autism as one expression of that diversity, and remind participants that every Autistic child is different.
- 4 Keep the explanation brief and connected to the child they are holding in mind.

KEY MESSAGES

- Neurodiversity includes all brains.
- Autism is a valid neurotype, not something to fix, change or hide.
- The workshop offers common patterns, while each child remains an individual.

Neurodiversity affirming

Differences are not deficits

Acknowledging different ways of knowing, doing, being and belonging

All people have strengths and experience challenges

There is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave

Everyone experiences and interacts with the world differently

Neurodiversity affirming

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:06 - 10:09

Explain the neurodiversity-affirming approach used throughout the day.

WHAT TO DO

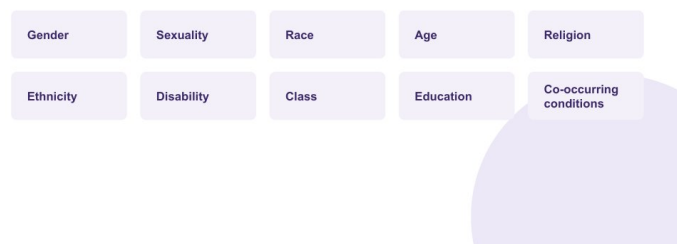
- 1 Walk through the points on the slide without adding a long definition.
- 2 Connect the points to the strengths and joys participants wrote about their child earlier.
- 3 Clarify that a strengths-based approach does not ignore difficulty, support needs or hard days.
- 4 Model language that describes what the environment and support need to look like, without blaming the child or the family.

KEY MESSAGES

- Differences are not deficits.
- All people have strengths and experience challenges.
- There is no right or wrong way to think, learn or behave.
- Everyone experiences and interacts with the world differently.

Intersectionality

People have many different parts to their identity. When these overlap, they can affect the opportunities, support, barriers and experiences a person has in life.



Intersectionality

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:09 - 10:11

Recognise that autism is one part of a child's identity and experience.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that people have many parts to their identity.
- 2 Use the examples on the slide as prompts, not a checklist.
- 3 Explain that when these parts overlap, they can affect the opportunities, support, barriers and experiences a person has.
- 4 Do not ask participants to share personal or family identity information.

KEY MESSAGES

- A child is more than one label or identity.
- Support needs to take account of the whole child, the whole family and their context.
- Overlapping parts of identity can bring both challenges and benefits.

Autism as difference

Dynamic disability

Your child's capacity can change from minute to minute, day to day and term to term. Same child, different capacity.

Fluctuating capacity

**Autism as difference -
Dynamic disability**

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:11 - 10:13

Introduce autism as a dynamic disability and the idea of fluctuating capacity.**WHAT TO DO**

- 1 Explain that a child's capacity can change from minute to minute, day to day and term to term: same child, different capacity.
- 2 Give a home example: something your child managed easily on Saturday may not be possible on a Monday after a full school day.
- 3 Connect this to curiosity: when capacity changes, ask what else is going on rather than assuming the child is choosing not to.
- 4 Let participants know that capacity comes back in more detail in Session 3.

KEY MESSAGES

- Autism is a dynamic disability.
- Capacity can fluctuate: same child, different capacity.
- Support should respond to the child and the situation, not a fixed idea of what they can do.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid presenting one pattern of ability, need or capacity as universal.
- Do not add clinical, diagnostic or legal claims.

Thread Fluctuating capacity is developed in Session 3 (managing daily capacity) and Session 4 (the after-school crash).

Joy and flourishing

Autistic experience is human experience

Joy, connection and belonging matter.

Every family is different

It can take time to understand and support needs.

Small moments count

Small moments and successes can matter as much as big ones.

Doing things differently

is fine when it helps your family flourish.

Today

We will explore ways to understand needs and find supports that fit.

Joy and flourishing

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:13 - 10:15

Close the opening session with a whole-child view of flourishing and move into Session 2.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Connect the points on the slide to the child participants wrote about at the start.
- 2 Acknowledge that every family is different and it can take time to understand and support needs.
- 3 Name small moments and successes alongside bigger goals.
- 4 Introduce Session 2: sensory experience and Autistic thinking.

KEY MESSAGES

- Autistic experience is human experience.
- Joy, connection and belonging matter.
- Small moments and successes can matter as much as big ones.
- Doing things differently is fine when it helps your family flourish.

SESSION

2

10:15 - 11:00 · 45 MINUTES · 23 SLIDES

Understanding Autistic Experience: Sensory and Thinking

SESSION INTENT

Build a picture of each participant's child through three lenses: sensory experience, Autistic thinking and internal signals. The session is strengths-based: participants hear from Autistic people directly and apply each idea to their own child and home routines.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Name the eight senses and describe sensory processing as a response that is not a choice.
- Recognise the four sensory profiles as a map, not a label, see stimming as authentic expression, and look at one home routine through a sensory lens.
- Describe detail-first processing and deep focus (monotropism), and see the strengths they bring in their own child.
- Understand interoception and alexithymia and begin mapping their child's early signs of overwhelm.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
10:15 - 10:16	Opening frame	1	1
10:16 - 10:22	The eight senses and sensory processing	2-5	6
10:22 - 10:26	Sensory overwhelm and sensory joy	6-7	4
10:26 - 10:36	Sensory profiles, stimming and home routine activity	8-10	10
10:36 - 10:42	Detail-first and deep focus	11-13	6
10:42 - 10:46	Executive functioning	14-16	4
10:46 - 10:51	Autistic thinking video and discussion	17-18	5
10:51 - 10:59	Internal signals and reading the signs	19-22	8
10:59 - 11:00	Close and Morning Tea	23	1

PREPARE

- ☐ Overwhelm and sensory joy video clips cued and tested with sound and captions.
- ☐ Autistic thinking video clip cued (once sourced).
- ☐ Participant Workbooks open to Session 2.
- ☐ Tables set for pair and small-group discussion.



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 2

Understanding Autistic Experience:

Sensory and Thinking

Understanding Autistic Experience: Sensory and Thinking

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:15 - 10:16

Orient the room: this session builds a picture of each participant's child.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Orient the room before starting.
- 2 Refer back to the child participants wrote about in Session 1 (What I love and value about my child) and ask them to keep that child in mind.

KEY MESSAGES

- This session is strengths-based.
- The lenses are not deficit labels - they are tools for understanding.
- The goal is recognition and shared understanding of the Autistic experience.

YOU MIGHT SAY

In this session we are going to build a picture of your child. Not a list of what is hard, and not a catalogue of traits. A picture.

Each idea we look at is a piece. As we move through Session 2 and Session 3, the picture will be clearer. Keep that child in mind. Everything today is about them.

KEEP IN MIND

- This session is tight. If you are running behind, keep the thinking discussion on slide 18 to one question in pairs, and take no whole-room responses after the video on slide 17. Keep the sensory activity (slide 10) and reading the signs (slide 22), as later sessions build on them.

Thread This is the opening frame. The "coming into focus" image logic starts here - fragments that build into a whole. Return to it at the close of Session 3.

Sensory



Sensory

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:16 - 10:17

Set sensory experience as the foundation for everything that follows.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Brief pause after speaking, then move to the senses.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Before we talk about thinking, or communication, or connection - we start here. With the senses. Because before your child has thought a single thought, the world has already arrived. And how it arrives matters.

Thread Sensory is the starting point: thinking, communication and connection all flow from it.



What is sensory processing?

What is sensory processing?

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:17 - 10:18

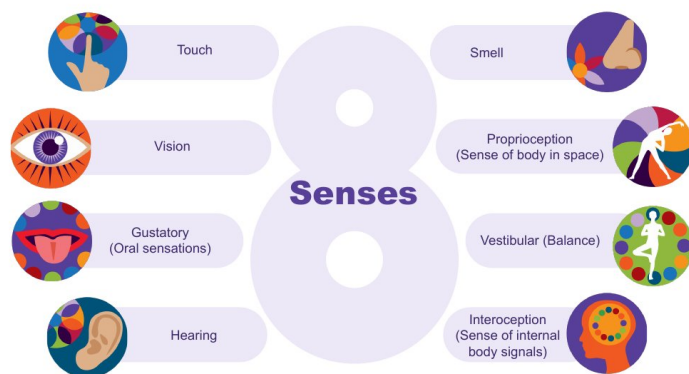
Ask the room what sensory processing means before giving the definition.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask: What is sensory processing?
- 2 Take one or two responses, then give the definition.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Sensory processing is the way the brain receives, processes and responds to information from the senses.



Senses

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:18 - 10:20

Introduce the eight senses, including the three less well-known senses.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Start with the five senses many of us were taught about: touch, vision, taste, hearing and smell.
- 2 Ask the room: there are three more senses that are less well known. Can you name them? Give a moment for responses.
- 3 Name proprioception, vestibular and interoception, using the descriptions on the slide.
- 4 Flag interoception and park it: it returns later in the session.

KEY MESSAGES

- There are 8 senses, not 5.
- The hidden three are often where Autistic differences show up most, and they are easy to miss.
- Interoception is flagged here and developed later - plant that seed.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Proprioception is the sense of where the body is in space. Children who crash into things, seek heavy pressure, or need to feel their body may be seeking proprioceptive input.

Vestibular is balance and movement. Your child who needs to rock, spin, or keep moving may be regulating through this sense.

Interoception is the body's inside sense - and it is one of the most important for understanding your child. Park it for now.

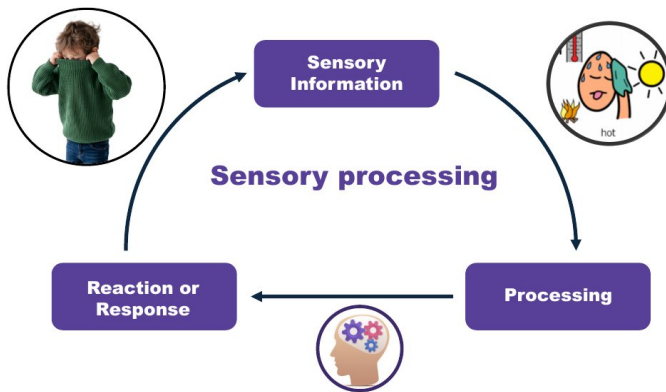
We will come back to interoception, it connects to a lot of what follows.

Background Touch (tactile) is received through the skin and gives information about texture, pain, pressure and temperature. Vision gives depth, colour, size, shape and where objects are in space. The gustatory sense is taste, and also other oral sensations such as texture, temperature, the size of food in the mouth and how much pressure is needed when chewing. Hearing (auditory) tells us how far away a sound is, how loud it is, its pitch and whether it is familiar. Smell (olfactory) can link strongly to emotional memory, so some smells trigger emotions more quickly than other senses. Proprioception comes through joints, muscles, ligaments and deep in the skin; differences may mean bumping into things. The vestibular sense sits in the middle ear and tells the brain how fast and in which direction the head is moving, and supports balance; a child may love spinning, or may get car sick easily or feel off balance on stairs. Interoception helps answer "how am I doing?": knowing when to go to the toilet, when you are tired, hungry, thirsty, hot or cold, or becoming angry or upset, and it plays a part in self-regulation. There is lots of crossover between the senses: in any situation we use all or most of them.

Thread Interoception returns as a full section in slides 19 - 22.

RESOURCES

- Interoception webinar recording and resources - Positive Partnerships website



Sensory processing

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:20 - 10:22

Walk through the sensory processing cycle with an everyday example.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk the cycle on the slide: sensory information, processing, reaction or response.
- 2 Use the jumper example.

KEY MESSAGES

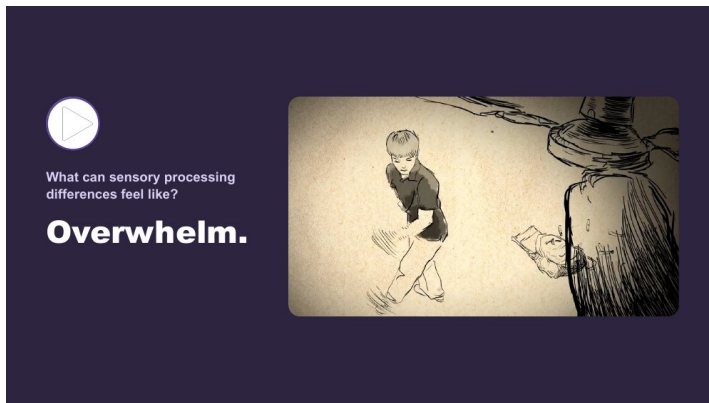
- The way the brain processes and responds to sensory information is not a choice.
- A visible reaction is only one part of the full process.

YOU MIGHT SAY

If you think about what is involved in someone taking their jumper off when they get too hot: first, sensory information is received to tell them they are getting too hot. This is processed and related to previous experiences, like how they felt when they took their jumper off before. A response is generated - in this example, taking the jumper off.

Sensory processing helps us stay safe, keep track of what our body is doing, understand our environment, learn, and filter out information so we can pay attention and engage.

It is important to note that the way our brain processes sensory information and responds is not a choice.



What can sensory processing differences feel like? Overwhelm

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:22 - 10:24

Shift from understanding to felt recognition through a first-person account of sensory overload.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce both clips before playing the first one.
- 2 Play the overwhelm clip.
- 3 After the clip, give a moment. Do not speak immediately.

YOU MIGHT SAY

We are going to watch two short clips. One shows what sensory overload can feel like from the inside. One shows sensory joy - what it is like when the senses are working with you rather than against you. Both are real. Both belong in the room.

We do this in a few places today - we stop and hear from Autistic people directly. That is not an add-on. It is the evidence.

Some of you will have seen something you recognised. Some of you may not have. Both responses are fine.

KEEP IN MIND

- Parents may recognise their child's hardest moments in this clip. Give the pause, and keep any comments optional.

Thread This video does the same job as the thinking video (slide 17) and the communication video in Session 3: moving from intellectual understanding to felt recognition.



What can sensory processing differences feel like?

Joy.

What can sensory processing differences feel like? Joy

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:24 - 10:26

Show that sensory experience is also a source of richness and pleasure.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Play the sensory joy clip.
- 2 After the clip, speak to both clips together.

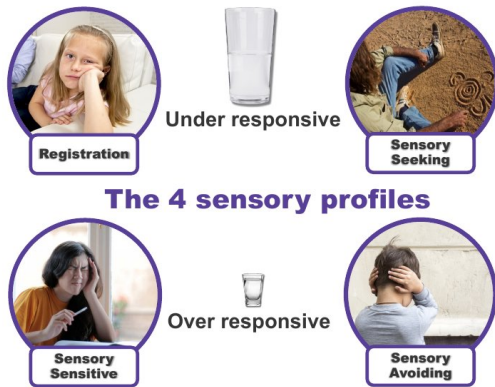
KEY MESSAGES

- Sensory experience includes both difficulty and joy.
- First-person accounts are more powerful than any explanation.
- Recognition - not information - is the goal here.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Sensory experience is not only a source of difficulty. For many Autistic people, it is also a source of richness, depth, and genuine pleasure.

The same nervous system that can be overwhelmed by sound can be transported by music. Both are true.



The 4 sensory profiles

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:26 - 10:29

Introduce four patterns of sensory response as a map, not a label.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the framework and talk through each profile briefly.
- 2 Link to the Sensory Profile Questionnaire some families will have met through an occupational therapist.
- 3 Name that a child can show different patterns across different senses.

KEY MESSAGES

- Four patterns: registration, seeking, sensitive, avoiding.
- Children can show different patterns across different senses.
- Patterns can shift with load and context.
- All patterns are the nervous system doing what it needs.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Winnie Dunn's research identified four patterns in how people respond to sensory input. These are not types of autism, they are patterns of sensory response. Your child may show more than one, and the pattern may shift depending on the day, the environment, or the load they are already carrying.

Registration (under-responsive): may not register input that others pick up. May seem unaware, dreamy, hard to reach.

Sensory Seeking: actively looks for more input. Movement, touch, sound. The body asking for what it needs.

Sensory Sensitive (over-responsive, passive): notices everything. Distracted, finds busy environments very hard, but does not necessarily act on it.

Sensory Avoiding (over-responsive, active): actively works to reduce input. Covers ears, avoids crowds, refuses certain textures.

A child can be seeking in some senses and avoiding in others. This is a map, not a label.

Background These four profiles are part of a sensory processing framework developed by Professor Winnie Dunn, an occupational therapist at the University of Missouri. Parents may have seen it if an occupational therapist has asked them to complete a Sensory Profile Questionnaire. The profiles are also known as seeker, bystander (registration), avoider and sensor (sensitive). Everyone has a different comfort level, or a different sized cup, for sensory information, which may lead to a different response. A person may have a different sized cup for different senses, so they could have a number of sensory profiles. A sensory profile is not a choice; it relates to how the brain responds to sensory information.

Sensory processing

Stimming and authentic expression**What stimming is**

Repetitive movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, spinning or humming.

Stimming can help your child regulate, express joy, focus or cope. It is authentic expression and often a sign of regulation, not something to stop by default.

What you can do

- Notice what it does for your child.
- Make space for it at home.
- Only redirect if it causes harm.
- Help others understand.

Stimming and authentic expression

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:29 - 10:32

Recognise stimming as authentic expression that often helps a child regulate, and think about how to make space for it at home.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Link from the sensory profiles: many children seek or manage sensory input through movement and sound.
- 2 Explain what stimming is, using the left side of the slide: repetitive movements or sounds that can help your child regulate, express joy, focus or cope.
- 3 Name that stimming is authentic expression and often a sign of regulation, not something to stop by default.
- 4 Walk through what parents can do on the right side of the slide.
- 5 If people wish to, invite one or two examples of how stimming looks for their child.

KEY MESSAGES

- Stimming is repetitive movement or sound that can help with regulation, joy, focus and coping.
- It is authentic expression and often a sign of regulation, not something to stop by default.
- Notice what it does for your child, make space for it, only redirect if it causes harm, and help others understand.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Rocking, flapping, spinning, humming, tapping, repeating a sound. Most of us do something like this, like clicking a pen or jiggling a leg. For many Autistic children, stimming is how the body settles, focuses or shows joy. If we stop it, we can take away something that was helping.

KEEP IN MIND

- There is no pressure to stop stimming. Avoid framing it as a behaviour to reduce or replace.
- Some children mask their stims at school or in public to fit in, and that takes energy. Home can be a place where they do not need to.
- If a stim causes harm, look for another way to meet the same need rather than simply stopping it.

Background Stimming is common among Autistic people. Many Autistic adults describe it as helping with regulation, focus and expressing emotion, including joy, and describe holding stims back as tiring. This links to masking in Session 3.

Thread Follows sensory seeking on the sensory profiles slide, and links forward to masking in Session 3.

Sensory Activity

Choose one familiar routine at home, like getting ready for school, mealtimes or bathtime.

- 1 What sensory demands does it create?
- 2 What could make it easier, or give more choice?
- 3 What would you like to find out from your child?

Sensory activity

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

10:32 - 10:36

GROUPING

Pairs or tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Sensory activity

Apply sensory thinking to one familiar routine at home.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to choose one familiar routine at home, like getting ready for school, mealtimes or bathtime.
- 2 Work through the three questions on the slide.
- 3 Invite pairs or tables to share, then take one or two examples from the room.

KEY MESSAGES

- Everyday routines carry sensory demands that are easy to miss.
- Small changes and more choice can make a routine easier.
- Your child is a source of information about what the routine feels like.

ACTIVITY

Pair or table discussion pairs or tables · 4 minutes

Choose one familiar routine at home, like getting ready for school, mealtimes or bathtime. What sensory demands does it create? What could make it easier, or give more choice? What would you like to find out from your child?

- 1 Give a minute for each person to choose a routine.
- 2 Pairs or tables talk through the three questions.
- 3 Take one or two examples from the room.

Close: Name that looking at the sensory demands of a routine is a starting point for curiosity, not proof of what your child feels.

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep the focus on the routine and its demands, not on the child getting it wrong or the parent getting it wrong.



Thinking

Thinking

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:36 - 10:37

Introduce the thinking section.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name that the session now moves from how the world arrives to how your child's mind takes it in and where attention goes.
- 2 Move straight to the detail-first brain.

KEY MESSAGES

- Present these as patterns participants may recognise, not assumptions about every Autistic child.

The Detail-First Brain



The Detail-First Brain

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:37 - 10:40

Introduce detail-first (bottom-up) processing and the strengths it produces.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Open with the contrast between filtering first and taking in the detail first.
- 2 Use the images on the slide to show the whole picture building from the pieces.
- 3 Move through the strengths slowly. For each one, invite the room to connect it to their child, e.g. Pattern recognition, where do you see this? Deep memory, what does your child know by heart? Honesty and directness, how does this show up?

KEY MESSAGES

- Autistic cognition builds from detail up - bottom-up processing.
- This connects to sensory intensity, literal language, and everything that follows.
- The strengths listed are genuine features, not compensations.
- Parents who leave with vocabulary for these strengths will notice and build on them actively.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Most brains filter first - they predict what is there based on expectation and fill in the rest. The detail-first brain does not filter first. It takes in what is actually there. Then it builds the whole picture from those pieces upward. That is bottom-up processing.

This is the architecture that connects sensory intensity, literal language, pattern recognition, and deep focus. They are not a list of separate Autistic traits. They are features of the same way of taking in the world.

Your child may pick up on small details: a tiny change in routine, a background sound, an inconsistency in what someone said. They are not being pedantic. They are seeing accurately.

What this produces: pattern recognition, systems thinking, deep memory, logical precision, honesty and directness, depth of connection, intense engagement. These are not future potential. They are present now.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some parents in this room will not have heard their child described with strengths-based cognitive framing before. The typical frame is "despite X they can Y". This is different. These are genuine features of how this brain works. The parent who names their child's pattern recognition as a strength is doing something meaningful for their child's identity and sense of self.

Background Some research suggests stronger bottom-up processing in Autistic people, with less top-down filtering. The practical implication: the environment is registered more fully, more specifically, and less pre-organised before reaching conscious awareness. This produces precision and depth. It also produces load: the same full page that generates pattern recognition also generates sensory overload.

The Deep Focus Brain



The Deep Focus Brain

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:40 - 10:42

Introduce monotropism: deep interests, transitions and flow.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask the room: do your thoughts travel across many different topics, or do they tend to go deep on one? Give a moment to reflect. Many parents will recognise this in themselves.
- 2 Use the torch and floodlight image on the slide.
- 3 Then name the key ideas: deep interests, transitions, flow.
- 4 Use the concrete example of the child being called to dinner.

KEY MESSAGES

- Monotropism: deep focus on fewer things at a time, not distraction or obsession.
- Deep interests can be a powerful route to learning, memory and genuine engagement (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005).
- Transitions can take real effort, because attention is deeply invested in what your child is doing.
- Flow is the positive expression of this architecture - the brain at its best.
- Named and described by Autistic people themselves.

YOU MIGHT SAY

The non-Autistic brain tends to spread attention across many things at once, like a floodlight. The Autistic brain tends to channel it fully into one thing at a time, like a torch beam. Neither is wrong. They illuminate different things.

Deep interests are not obsessions or fixations. They are the brain's most natural access to learning, memory, and joy.

Transitions can be hard because attention is deeply invested, not because your child is being difficult. With warning and scaffolding this becomes more manageable. The effort involved is real.

Flow - full absorption, time disappearing - is this brain at its most powerful. It is worth protecting.

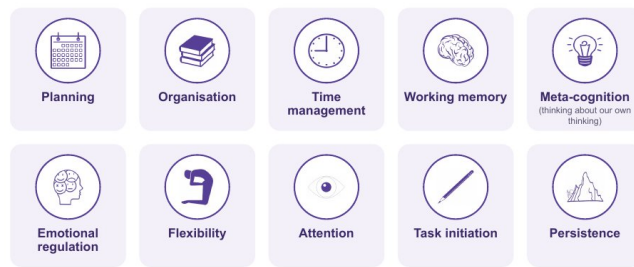
A child absorbed in building a LEGO set, reading about space, listening to the same song or watching the same episode again is not stuck. The brain is doing what it does best: going deep. Asking that child to stop and come to dinner is not a simple request. The tendrils are all the way in. Retracting them takes real effort and real time.

Background Monotropism was developed as a framework by Autistic researchers and advocates, and has been extended by Autistic community voices. It proposes that the core feature of Autistic attention is channelling into fewer things with greater depth, rather than distributing broadly. This explains deep interests, transition difficulty and the experience of flow. The tendril theory comic illustrates it practically: attention extends like tendrils into what the mind is engaged with; switching means retracting all of them, which takes time and costs something. This connects directly to the detail-first brain: one explains how the world arrives, the other where attention goes once it has. Monotropism: Murray, Lesser and Lawson (2005).

RESOURCES

- Tendril theory comic - <https://eisforerin.com/2015/08/10/tendril-theory/>

Executive Functioning



Executive Functioning

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:42 - 10:44

Make executive functioning visible as a set of everyday processes.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Briefly name the functions on the slide: planning, organisation, time management, working memory, meta-cognition (thinking about our own thinking), emotional regulation, flexibility, attention, task initiation and persistence.
- 2 Explain that the next two slides show how two of these connect to the detail-first brain and the deep focus brain.
- 3 Keep this as a map of processes, not a list of deficits.

KEY MESSAGES

- Executive functioning includes the processes involved in starting, organising, sequencing and switching between tasks.
- Identifying the difficult part helps identify a useful support.

Executive functioning example

Getting started on a task

Detail-First Brain

Starting can be hard when the whole task is not clear yet.

Your child may not be able to identify the first step they need to take to get started.



Executive functioning example - Getting started on a task

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:44 - 10:45

Link getting started to the detail-first brain.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Use the getting-ready-for-school image on the slide.
- 2 Explain that starting can be hard when the whole task is not clear yet: your child may not be able to identify the first step.
- 3 Ask what might help at home, such as showing the first step or breaking the task into visible parts.

KEY MESSAGES

- Starting can be hard when the whole task is not clear yet.
- A practical support starts with understanding which part of the task is hard.

Executive functioning example

Switching focus**Deep Focus Brain**

It can be difficult for your child to stop what they are doing and switch focus.

Transitions and unexpected interruptions can feel big because the mind is deeply focused on a task - it can feel like 'tunnel vision' for the mind.

Executive functioning example - Switching focus

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:45 - 10:46**Link switching focus to the deep focus brain.****WHAT TO DO**

- 1 Use the image on the slide of a child deep in play when it is dinner time.
- 2 Explain that stopping and switching can be difficult because the mind is deeply focused - it can feel like tunnel vision for the mind.
- 3 Connect back to the torch beam: warning and time help.

KEY MESSAGES

- Starting and switching are different demands.
- Transitions and unexpected interruptions can feel big when the mind is deeply focused.



How can Autistic thinking feel?



How can Autistic thinking feel?

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:46 - 10:48

Hear a first-person account of deep focus and changing focus.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the video as one young person's experience of focusing and transitioning.
- 2 Play the video, then give a moment before moving on.

Thread Same pattern as the sensory clips: stop and hear from Autistic people directly.

Discussion activity



- What are your child's deep interests?
- What do you notice about when they are fully engaged with these interests?
- When does your child have trouble getting started or shifting their attention?
- Have you seen your child fully absorbed in something at home? What were they doing?

Discussion activity - Your child's thinking

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:48 - 10:51

GROUPING

Pairs or tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Thinking discussion

Personalise the thinking concepts: move from "I understand this" to "I can see this in my child".

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Direct people to the questions on the slide.
- 2 Invite pairs or table groups to share with each other before taking a few whole-room responses.
- 3 Bring the room back with: What came up for people? Take 2 - 3 responses. You do not need to comment extensively on each; the room hearing each other is the consolidation.
- 4 Close with the line below.

KEY MESSAGES

- The questions map onto the concepts: detail-first, deep interests, starting and switching, and flow.
- Parents who can name these things in their child leave the room with something practical and immediate.
- The activity holds strengths alongside challenges: flow and deep interests sit alongside starting and shifting.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Everything you have just described, that IS the thinking brain at work. Noticing it is the beginning of working with it rather than against it.

ACTIVITY

Pair or table share pairs or tables · 3 minutes

What are your child's deep interests? What do you notice when they are fully engaged with these interests? When does your child have trouble getting started or shifting their attention? Have you seen your child fully absorbed in something at home? What were they doing?

- 1 Invite participants to choose the questions most relevant to them.
- 2 Keep the pair or table share brief.
- 3 Take 2 - 3 whole-room responses.

Close: Everything you have just described is the thinking brain at work.

KEEP IN MIND

- The facilitator's job here is to hold the space rather than add more content. What parents say to each other will likely do more work than the preceding slides.

Thread The last question, about flow, sets up the next question: what happens to that focus when your child tries to communicate or connect? That is picked up in Session 3.

Internal signals



Internal signals

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:51 - 10:52

Return to interoception, parked earlier, as another part of the picture of your child.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Remind participants of the "body's inside sense" flagged on the senses slide.
- 2 Introduce internal signals as the next piece of the picture.

Making sense of what's happening inside

Interoception

Understanding our body's internal signals

Temperature

Hunger

Thirst

Do I need the bathroom?



Alexithymia

Difficulty identifying and describing emotions and feelings

Am I excited or am I anxious?

Is crying always sadness?

What is my friend feeling?

Making sense of what's happening inside

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:52 - 10:54

Distinguish noticing body signals (interoception) from identifying and describing emotions (alexithymia).

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Use the slide wording: interoception is understanding our body's internal signals; alexithymia is difficulty identifying and describing emotions and feelings.
- 2 Use the examples on the slide: temperature, hunger, thirst, do I need the bathroom? Am I excited or am I anxious? Is crying always sadness? What is my friend feeling?
- 3 Give a home example: a child who does not notice hunger until they are very distressed, or who cannot tell whether a fluttery feeling is excitement or worry before a birthday party.
- 4 Avoid diagnosing participants or their children from the examples.

KEY MESSAGES

- Noticing body signals and understanding emotions are related, but they are not the same thing.
- A child may need support to notice, interpret or communicate what is happening inside.

Reading the signs: Building understanding together

Sometimes children experience a build-up inside of them, but the surface does not show it.

The more we understand a child's early signs, the less we wait for distress to become obvious.

Building a 'map' (a shared understanding) of these signs together with others can help everyone respond in a more consistent way.



Reading the signs: Building understanding together

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

10:54 - 10:56

Explore how adults can notice early signs before distress becomes obvious.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that sometimes a build-up is happening inside a child even when the surface does not show it.
- 2 Explain that the more we understand a child's early signs, the less we wait for distress to become obvious.
- 3 Introduce the idea of a shared map of these signs, built with others such as family members and school, so everyone can respond more consistently.

KEY MESSAGES

- Early signs may be individual and subtle.
- Shared understanding helps people respond more consistently.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not suggest that a parent missed signs or should have seen something coming. Many build-ups are not visible at all.

Discussion activity



- What signs and changes do you notice before your child becomes overwhelmed?
- What would be useful for others to know about these signs?



Discussion activity - Reading the signs

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

10:56 - 10:59

GROUPING

On your own, then tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Reading the signs

Help participants name their child's early signs in words they could share with others.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Give quiet thinking time before sharing.
- 2 Invite examples without requiring personal disclosure.
- 3 Encourage descriptive language that could be shared with school or other carers.

KEY MESSAGES

- Early signs look different for each child.
- Descriptive information helps home and school build a shared understanding.

ACTIVITY

Think, write and optional share on your own, then tables · 3 minutes

What signs and changes do you notice before your child becomes overwhelmed? What would be useful for others to know about these signs?

- 1 Give a minute of quiet writing time.
- 2 Invite optional sharing at tables.
- 3 Encourage descriptions of what can be seen or heard, rather than labels.

Close: Let participants know this map is useful to bring to conversations with school in Session 5.

Thread The early-signs map links to managing daily capacity (Session 3) and partnership with the school (Session 5).

After Morning Tea

Communication, connection and managing daily capacity



After Morning Tea

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

10:59 - 11:00

Wrap up Session 2 and introduce Session 3.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Summarise sensory experience, thinking and internal signals as pieces of the picture.
- 2 Explain that after Morning Tea the picture continues with communication, connection and managing daily capacity.
- 3 Invite participants to keep thinking about the same child.
- 4 Remind participants Morning Tea is 11:00 - 11:15.

Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity

SESSION INTENT

Explore how your child communicates, connects and manages changing daily capacity, then close the morning by bringing the separate lenses back to the whole child and positive Autistic identity. Parents map their child's communication world, consider what knowledge should travel with them, and reflect on connection and the cost of appearing fine.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Recognise the many ways their child communicates, and that speech is one part of communication.
- Distinguish understanding from expressing, and name supports such as clear language, processing time and visual supports.
- Describe connection as two-way, and identify the kinds of connection their child enjoys.
- Use the battery and spoon analogies to think about changing capacity and the cost of masking.
- Connect positive Autistic identity and belonging with their child's wellbeing.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
11:15 - 11:16	Welcome back and session opening	1	1
11:16 - 11:42	Communication: ways of communicating, communication network and supports	2-9	26
11:42 - 11:58	Connection: double empathy, being social and discussion	10-13	16
11:58 - 12:04	Managing daily capacity: batteries, spoons and fluctuating capacity	14-16	6
12:04 - 12:12	Masking and discussion	17-19	8
12:12 - 12:15	Positive Autistic Identity and close before lunch	20	3

PREPARE

- ☐ Workbooks and pens.
- ☐ Purple, blue and orange Post-it notes on each table, and wall or board space for notes grouped by colour.
- ☐ Three videos tested with sound: Communication experiences (slide 5), Being social (slide 11) and Masking (slide 17).
- ☐ Edited captions switched on and transcripts available for each video.
- ☐ Slide 20 closing script read through beforehand so it can be delivered slowly.
- ☐ Lunch arrangements confirmed so the close on slide 20 is not rushed.



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 3

Understanding Autistic Experience:

Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity.

Understanding Autistic Experience: Communication, Connection and Managing Daily Capacity

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

11:15 - 11:16

Welcome participants back from morning tea and connect Session 3 with the sensory, thinking and internal-signal lenses from Session 2.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Welcome participants back from morning tea.
- 2 Briefly connect sensory experience, thinking and internal signals with the three areas in this session: communication, connection and managing daily capacity.
- 3 Explain that the session keeps building one whole picture of their child rather than separate lists.
- 4 Ask participants to keep their own child in mind throughout.

KEY MESSAGES

- Communication, connection and capacity are shaped by the experiences already explored.
- Keep the individual child in mind throughout the session.

KEEP IN MIND

- This session is tight before lunch. If you are running behind, skip the optional sharing on slide 9 (visual supports) and move on from the Being social video (slide 11) without taking responses. Protect the time for the close on slide 20.

Thread Sessions 2 and 3 build one picture of the child. This session closes that picture on slide 20, Positive Autistic Identity, before lunch.



Communication

Communication

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

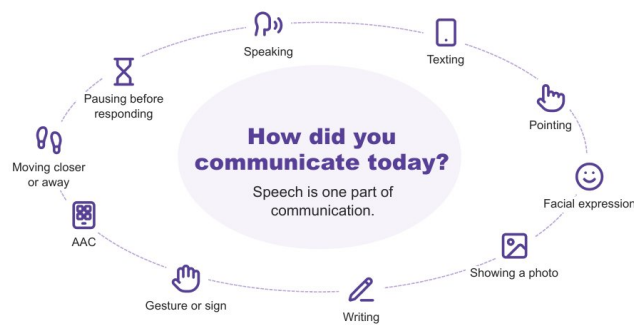
CLOCK

11:16 - 11:17

Open the communication section.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the first section: communication.
- 2 Move straight to the warm-up on the next slide.



How did you communicate today?

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

11:17 - 11:19

GROUPING

Whole room

Warm up with participants' own everyday communication and show that speech is one part of communication.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to think quietly of three ways they have communicated since waking up.
- 2 Pause for about 20 seconds.
- 3 Take only two or three responses. Reflect back the variety you hear, for example a text message, a wave, a look, or taking a moment before answering.
- 4 For families who have been told their child needs to "use their words", offer this as a gentle reframe: pointing, a device, a look or moving away are all ways of communicating.

KEY MESSAGES

- Everyone communicates in many ways, every day. Speech is one part of communication.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Let's start with a quick, quiet think. Since you woke up this morning, how have you communicated? See if you can think of three different ways.

Would two or three people be happy to share one?

We all move between different ways of communicating, often without noticing. Every way on this slide is real communication. No way is more valid than another.

ACTIVITY

Quiet think with optional sharing whole room · 1 to 1.5 minutes

Silently think of three ways you have communicated since waking. Sharing is optional.

- 1 Give about 20 seconds of quiet thinking time.
- 2 Invite two or three people to share one way each.

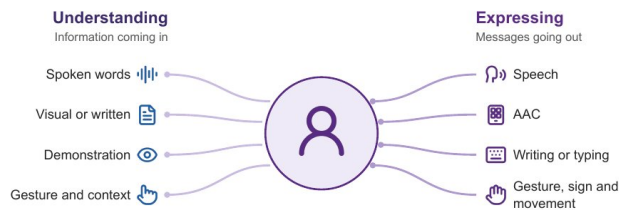
Close: Reflect back the variety you heard: every way on the slide is real communication.

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep this brief. It is a warm-up, not a discussion.
- Do not use percentages or claims about how much of communication is spoken or non-spoken.

Understanding and expressing

How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.



Understanding and expressing

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

11:19 - 11:21

Distinguish understanding (information coming in) from expressing (messages going out), and show that one does not predict the other.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the two sides of the slide: understanding, or information coming in, and expressing, or messages going out.
- 2 Give the plain AAC explanation.
- 3 Invite participants to think about what helps their child understand, and what helps their child express.

KEY MESSAGES

- How much someone speaks does not tell us how much they understand.
- Autistic people have varied communication profiles, and communication can change with the person, place, demands and how someone is feeling.
- Repeating words, phrases or scripts (echolalia and scripting) can be communication, and a way for your child to process what is happening. Be curious about what it might mean.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Autistic people have varied communication profiles. Someone may express a great deal but need support to understand spoken information. Someone else may understand more than they can easily express.

Communication can also change depending on the person, place, demands and how someone is feeling.

AAC means augmentative and alternative communication. It may include gesture, signs, a communication board or book, typing or a communication device. Some people use AAC alongside speech and some use it instead of speech.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not assume fluent speech means full understanding. Do not assume limited speech means limited understanding.

Background Receptive communication means how a person receives and makes sense of information. Expressive communication means how a person shares messages, ideas, feelings and choices through any communication method. AAC means augmentative and alternative communication: ways to support speech or communicate without speech, such as signs, communication books, typing or a speech-generating device. Facilitator background only: gestalt language processing (GLP) is a term used in a proposed account of learning language through larger phrases or chunks. Echolalia means repeating words or phrases, immediately or later. They are not interchangeable terms. This session does not teach GLP or Natural Language Acquisition stages; explaining the framework and its evidence needs a separate discussion. Hutchins et al. (2024) questions the evidence for these categories and stages. This does not diminish the value of repeated or scripted language. Respond with curiosity, consider context and do not assume it is meaningless or something to stop. Families do not need a GLP label before communication is respected or supported.

RESOURCES

- Hutchins et al. (2024): <https://doi.org/10.1177/23969415241249944>



Communication experiences

What stood out to you about what supported communication?



Communication experiences

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

11:21 - 11:25

GROUPING

Whole room

Hear first-person accounts of what supports communication.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Before the video, read the prompt: "As you watch, notice what supports communication. Choose one idea that stands out to you."
- 2 Check captions are switched on.
- 3 Play the video (keep the clip to around 2.5 minutes).
- 4 After the video, click once to reveal the question and ask it.
- 5 Take one response, or two if time allows. Use the optional prompts only if the room is quiet.

KEY MESSAGES

- There is no single Autistic communication profile. Autistic people describe what helps them communicate in many different ways.

YOU MIGHT SAY

What stood out to you about what supported communication?

ACTIVITY

Video and brief response whole room · 4 minutes including playback

What stood out to you about what supported communication?

- 1 Optional prompt: What communication strengths did you notice?
- 2 Optional prompt: What did another person do that helped?
- 3 Optional prompt: What difference did the environment or available communication method make?

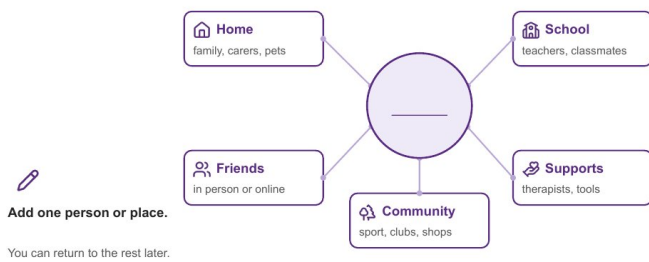
Close: Thank responses and move on without summarising the speakers.

KEEP IN MIND

- Let the voices in the video lead. Avoid summarising or generalising what speakers said.
- Use accurate, edited captions (not auto-generated only) and have a transcript available.
- If the video is inserted to play on click, the question appears on the following click.

Thread This is one of several points in the day where the room hears directly from Autistic people.

Who is part of the communication network?



Who is part of the communication network?

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

11:25 - 11:28

GROUPING

Individual

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Who is part of the communication network?

Map the people and places in the child's communication world, starting with one.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to turn to "Who is part of the communication network?" in the Workbook.
- 2 Allow about 1.5 minutes of quiet time to add one person or place. Offer to write for anyone who would like help.
- 3 Share the points below while people write.

KEY MESSAGES

- Children communicate with many people in many places. Each person may see a different part of the communication picture.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Please turn to "Who is part of the communication network?" in your Workbook. Your child is in the centre. Around them are home, school, friends, community and supports.

Think about who is part of your child's communication network. Add one person or place now. You can return to the rest later.

You can write names, draw or use dot points.

You do not need to complete every box. A box can hold many people, one person, or nobody yet.

Different people may see different parts of your child's communication. A grandparent, a coach and a teacher may each notice something different.

This activity is not about deciding who understands your child best.

You can come back to this page with your child, family members, educators or other communication partners.

ACTIVITY

Individual mapping individual · 3 minutes (about 1.5 minutes writing)

Add one person or place to your child's communication network.

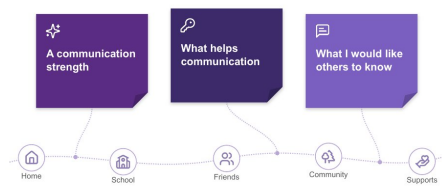
- 1 Point to the network page in the Workbook.
- 2 Give quiet writing time.
- 3 Offer to scribe for anyone who wants help.

Close: Remind participants they can finish the page later, with their child or others.

KEEP IN MIND

- Networks can be small or changing. Normalise empty boxes.
- The workbook belongs to the family. They decide what goes in it.

What should travel between people and places?



What should travel between people and places?

SUGGESTED TIME

7 min

CLOCK

11:28 - 11:35

GROUPING

Individual, then whole room

WORKBOOK

Workbook - What should travel between people and places?

Identify the communication knowledge families hold that should travel with their child between home, school and community.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Check purple, blue and orange Post-it notes are on each table and a wall or board space is ready, grouped by colour.
- 2 Explain the three boxes, which match "What should travel between people and places?" in the Workbook.
- 3 Allow about 3 minutes of writing, then about 4 minutes of optional sharing.
- 4 Invite people to add a note to the board or read one out if they are comfortable.
- 5 Notice themes on the blue notes. You will return to them on the next slide.

KEY MESSAGES

- Families hold valuable knowledge about communication. When that knowledge travels between home, school and community, children do not have to start again with every new person.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Let's think about what should travel with your child between people and places. The three colours match the three boxes on "What should travel between people and places?" in your workbook.

Purple is a communication strength. Blue is something that helps communication. Orange is something you would like others to know.

You can write one note, two or all three. You can use your own child or a made-up example. You can keep your notes private if you prefer.

If you are comfortable, add a note to the board or read one out.

ACTIVITY

Colour-coded Post-it notes with optional sharing individual, then whole room · 7 minutes (about 3 writing, about 4 sharing)

Purple: a communication strength. Blue: what helps communication. Orange: what I would like others to know.

- 1 Writing: about 3 minutes.
- 2 Sharing: about 4 minutes. Sharing is optional.

Bring the room back

- What similarities do you notice?
- What strengths might be missed if we look only for speech?
- Which supports change what other people do or provide?
- What information might help at school?
- Did another person's contribution prompt a new thought?

Close: Pick up the themes on the blue notes as you move into supporting communication.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not ask individuals to share. Thank every contribution without ranking it.
- If a note names a child or school, invite the writer to keep it.

Thread The blue notes (what helps communication) lead into the three supports on the next slide.

How can we support communication?



How can we support communication?

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

11:35 - 11:38

Introduce three ways to support communication in everyday life.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the three strategies on the slide.
- 2 Link back to what participants wrote on the blue notes.
- 3 The three supports are summarised in the Session 3 key ideas in the workbook. There is no activity on this slide.

KEY MESSAGES

- The right support depends on the person and the moment.

YOU MIGHT SAY

There are three strategies we can use. Clear communication means using familiar words and giving one idea or step at a time. Processing time means pausing so the person has time to understand and respond. Visual supports mean showing information as well as saying it. Let's look at what these can look like.

KEEP IN MIND

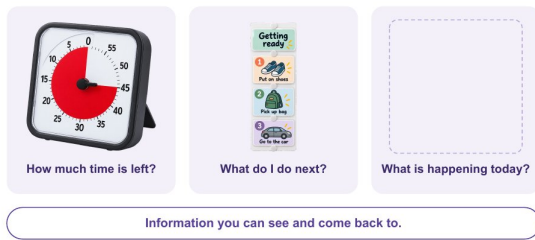
- These are options to match to the person, not a checklist or a guarantee.
- Keep AAC available and allow responses through the person's preferred methods, including refusal.
- Avoid filling every pause with more words.

Background Processing time is time to make sense of information, organise a response and communicate it. Clear communication means familiar, specific language in a form and amount the person can access. Communication partner guidance includes adapting language and allowing response time. AAC guidance also includes visual supports and access across settings (ASHA, n.d.; Brady et al., 2016).

RESOURCES

- ASHA AAC Practice Portal
- Brady et al. (2016)

What are visual supports?



What are visual supports?

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

11:38 - 11:42

GROUPING

Whole room

Help parents recognise what visual supports are through familiar examples.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the three examples on the slide: timer, sequence, daily schedule.
- 2 Connect to visual information participants already use themselves.
- 3 If time allows, invite one or two brief examples of visual information already used at home. This is an introduction, not another task to complete.

KEY MESSAGES

- Visual supports are information you can see and come back to.
- The useful format will be different for each person.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Visual supports help make information clear. They give us something to look at and come back to. This timer shows how much time is left. A sequence shows what to do next. A daily schedule shows what is happening today.

You might already use a calendar, shopping list or reminder on your phone. The useful format will be different for each person.

What visual information do you already use at home?

ACTIVITY

Optional brief sharing whole room · 1 to 2 minutes

What visual information do you already use at home?

- 1 Invite one or two brief examples.
- 2 Ask what made the visual helpful in that situation.

Close: Name clear language, processing time and visuals as ways of making a message easier to understand.

KEEP IN MIND

- A visual support offers information, not a condition for access to a preferred activity.
- Match the format to the person and invite their preferences. Avoid evaluating or prescribing a particular visual system.
- Visual supports and AAC can overlap, but they are not interchangeable. Keep the person's communication methods available.

Background Visual supports can include objects, real photos, written words or symbols, on paper or a device. Check that the person understands the information and can access it when needed. The written sequence is an example of accessible information, not a test of compliance. The images illustrate formats, not recommended products. Avery et al. (2025) reviews caregiver-implemented visual supports for people with developmental disabilities. ASHA's AAC Practice Portal describes visual schedules and other visual supports. Use this evidence to explain options, not to promise the same result for every person.

RESOURCES

- Avery et al. (2025)
- ASHA AAC Practice Portal

Double Empathy



Double Empathy

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

11:42 - 11:46

Introduce connection as two-way: misunderstandings between people with different ways of experiencing and communicating happen in both directions.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the connection section and the double empathy idea.
- 2 Use the image of two children with a stream of colour and symbols between them: each is sending and receiving in their own way.
- 3 Explain that misunderstandings can occur in both directions when people have different experiences or communication styles.
- 4 Ask participants to keep this two-way frame in mind as the section moves into social interaction.

KEY MESSAGES

- Understanding is a shared responsibility.
- Connection can become easier when both people adjust and seek to understand.

YOU MIGHT SAY

When two people communicate differently, misunderstandings can happen on both sides. Often only one side gets the blame. Double empathy asks us to see it as a two-way gap that both people can work to bridge.

Many of you will already do this at home. You have learnt your child's way of communicating, and they have learnt yours.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid locating all responsibility for the misunderstanding in the Autistic person.

Background The double empathy idea was put forward by Autistic researcher Damian Milton. It describes breakdowns in understanding between Autistic and non-Autistic people as a mutual problem arising from different ways of experiencing the world, rather than a deficit in the Autistic person.

**Being social****Being social**

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

11:46 - 11:50

Share a first-person account of social interaction and connection.

WHAT TO DO

- 1** Introduce the clip as one person's experience of being social.
- 2** Check captions are on, then play the video.
- 3** Allow a quiet pause before asking what participants noticed.
- 4** Take one or two responses.

KEY MESSAGES

- Connection looks different for different people.

YOU MIGHT SAY

This is one person's experience of being social. As you watch, think about your own child.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not generalise the account to all Autistic people.

Thread Another point in the day where Autistic voices lead.

Social Interactions

Family

School

Community

Online



Social Interactions

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

11:50 - 11:53

Widen the picture of what social interaction can look like across family, school, community and online.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the four settings on the slide: family, school, community and online.
- 2 Identify a range of ways a child may interact, for example one-on-one, parallel play or engagement alongside others, info dumping (sharing a lot about an interest), and irregular contact.
- 3 Make connections to culture: families and communities have their own ways of being together.
- 4 Invite participants to think of the forms of connection their child already has.

KEY MESSAGES

- Connection can happen through conversation, shared interests, activity, quiet presence or online interaction.
- The most useful question is not whether a child is social enough, but what kinds of connection work for them.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid framing any one form of interaction as the goal.

Discussion activity



- When does your child seem most comfortable connecting with others?
- What kinds of connection do they enjoy?
(Talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly, online interaction?)
- Are there times when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- What can adults do to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?



Discussion activity: connection

SUGGESTED TIME

5 min

CLOCK

11:53 - 11:58

GROUPING

Tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Connection discussion

Explore the forms and conditions of connection the child enjoys, and what adults can change.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Offer the examples on the slide: talking, gaming, sport, making things, shared interests, being together quietly and online interaction.
- 2 Invite table discussion or private reflection.
- 3 Take a small number of examples and keep the focus on the child's preferences.

KEY MESSAGES

- Adults can change conditions around the child.

ACTIVITY

Discussion or private reflection tables · 5 minutes

When does your child seem most comfortable connecting with others?

- 1 What kinds of connection do they enjoy?
- 2 Are there times when being social seems enjoyable, and times when it seems tiring or overwhelming?
- 3 What could adults change around them to make social connection feel safer, easier or more meaningful?

Close: Name that meaningful connection may look different across people, places and days.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some children have few connections right now. Keep the tone free of comparison.



Managing Daily Capacity

Managing Daily Capacity

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

11:58 - 11:59

Open the section on energy and changing capacity.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the section and link it to the connection discussion: being social can be enjoyable and tiring at the same time.

Batteries and Spoons

Think of your child's energy as a battery.

Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day.

Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.



Batteries and Spoons

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

11:59 - 12:02

Introduce the battery and spoon analogies as practical ways to describe changing energy.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the slide text.
- 2 Introduce the spoons idea used in the Autistic community.
- 3 Finish on recharging: the right supports can restore some charge.

KEY MESSAGES

- Capacity is not the same every day.
- Every action uses up energy, and energy can be recharged.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Think of your child's energy as a battery. Every day starts with a charge amount, and it's not the same charge at the start of each day. Every action uses up energy. When the battery runs low, the body will show it.

In the Autistic community, many like to describe this as having a set of spoons. Each action uses up one or some spoons. When spoons are low, actions are hard to manage.

You can recharge! The right supports can regain some battery charge or extra spoons.

KEEP IN MIND

- Present both analogies as optional ways to describe capacity, not measures of ability.

Thread The battery returns in Session 4 (the after-school crash and your own battery).

Fluctuating Capacity



Fluctuating Capacity

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

12:02 - 12:04

Show that capacity changes from day to day and within a day.

WHAT TO DO

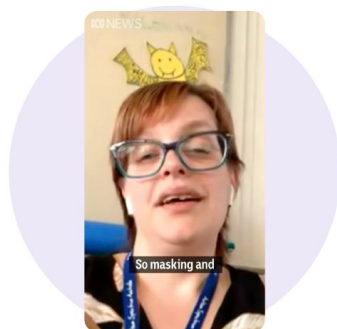
- 1 Use the image to show battery levels changing across a day and across days.
- 2 Invite participants to notice what costs their child energy and what lightens the load.

KEY MESSAGES

- A demand may be manageable on one day and too much on another.
- Understanding load helps adults plan support without treating fluctuation as unwillingness.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Like all people, Autistic children have good days and harder days. Their ability to manage school, social situations, communication, or daily tasks may change depending on stress, energy levels, sensory demands, and what else is happening in their life. This can impact them.

**Masking****Masking**

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:04 - 12:07**Introduce masking through a first-person account.****WHAT TO DO**

- 1 Link masking to batteries and spoons.
- 2 Check captions are on, then play the video.
- 3 Allow a moment of quiet afterwards.

YOU MIGHT SAY

There are other things that can impact our batteries or spoons. Let's watch a video about masking.

KEEP IN MIND

- Let the speaker's account lead. Do not generalise it to every Autistic child.

Masking and the cost of appearing fine



Masking and the cost of appearing fine

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

12:07 - 12:08

Contrast what others may see with what the child may be carrying afterwards.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Describe the image: on the left the child is managing at school, on the right the same child at home with an empty battery.
- 2 Name the effort that can sit behind appearing fine.

KEY MESSAGES

- Appearing fine does not always show the effort or load underneath.
- Changes to the environment may reduce the effort required.

Thread This sets up the after-school crash in Session 4.

Discussion activity



- When does your child seem to be working hard to appear "fine" when they are not?
- When and where do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Discussion activity: masking

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

12:08 - 12:12

GROUPING

Individual, then tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Masking discussion

Consider where the child works hard to appear fine, where they feel safest to be themselves, and what adults could change.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Give private thinking time before inviting discussion.
- 2 Invite one practical change where participants are ready to share.

KEY MESSAGES

- Safety can look like having less need to perform or hide parts of oneself.

ACTIVITY

Private thinking, then discussion individual, then tables · 4 minutes

When does your child seem to be working hard to appear "fine" when they are not?

- 1 When and where do they seem most comfortable being themselves?
- 2 What could we change to help them feel more comfortable and supported?

Close: Connect this discussion to the next slide by naming the value of knowing and being valued for who you are.

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep examples descriptive and avoid asking participants to prove that masking is occurring.
- Some parents may realise their child has been masking for a long time. Acknowledge this gently and without blame.

Positive Autistic Identity

A child who knows who they are -
and feels genuinely valued for it -
has more available for everything
else.



Positive Autistic Identity

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:12 - 12:15

Close Sessions 2 and 3 by bringing the separate lenses back to the whole child, then break for lunch.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 This is the closing slide of the morning. Deliver the close slowly, with purpose. Let the room settle before you begin.
- 2 Read the opening paragraph slowly. It names everything the morning covered as one coherent picture, so parents can make the connections themselves.
- 3 Leave the final sentence in the room.
- 4 Pause. Let it land. Do not fill the silence.
- 5 Then break for lunch.

KEY MESSAGES

- The cost is not just masking. It is managing the whole architecture of Autistic experience in a world not designed for it.
- Positive Autistic identity is a research-supported protective factor for mental health and wellbeing.
- Belonging is the precondition. When identity does not need to be managed on top of everything else, those resources become available for learning and connection.
- Agency is protective. Genuine choice over their own environment reduces cost directly.
- Autistic community connection is itself protective. Knowing other Autistic people share your experience matters.
- These are not extras. They are the conditions under which everything else becomes possible.

YOU MIGHT SAY

This morning, across Sessions 2 and 3, you have been building a picture of your child.

How the world arrives through their senses, more fully, more specifically, less filtered. How their brain builds understanding from the detail up, focuses deeply, and thinks in ways that produce real and specific strengths. How their internal world works. How they reach toward other people, and what that costs when the conditions are not designed for them.

Managing all of that, every day, in a world that was largely built for a different nervous system, takes resources. Sensory management. Social interpretation. Executive effort. Communication across a gap. Holding it together when the signals inside are not arriving clearly. And sometimes, performing fine when fine is not what is happening.

A child who knows who they are, and feels genuinely valued for it, has more of those resources available for everything else.

Research suggests what many Autistic adults describe: a positive sense of Autistic identity is linked with better mental health and wellbeing (Cooper, Smith and Russell, 2017; Corden, Brewer and Cage, 2021). Belonging is the precondition for all of it. When a child does not need to spend resources managing their identity on top of everything else, those resources become available for learning, connection, and self-knowledge.

Agency matters too: genuine choice over how they communicate, where they sit, when they step back. And knowing that other Autistic people share their experience, that Autistic adults have found belonging and purpose, is protective in its own right.

Your child is not alone in this. They are part of something.

The deepest thing you can do is support them to know themselves, and to know that who they are is worth knowing.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some parents will need a moment. That is the right outcome. Do not rush to lunch.

Background Research on Autistic identity and wellbeing suggests that positive Autistic identity, knowing yourself as Autistic and valuing that, is associated with better mental health outcomes, reduced anxiety, and greater resilience (Cooper, Smith and Russell, 2017; Corden, Brewer and Cage, 2021). This is distinct from general self-esteem. It is specifically the sense of Autistic identity as something to know and value, not manage or minimise, that provides protection. Belonging to Autistic peer networks amplifies this effect. The goal is not for your child to fit in. The goal is for your child to know who they are, and to find the people and places where that is valued. The phrase "managing all of that, every day, in a world largely built for a different nervous system" names the real cost honestly without being too heavy. It is not about what is wrong with the world. It is about what is true, and what follows from that truth. See Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) on social identity and Autistic wellbeing.

Thread This slide returns to the child the room has been thinking about all morning, now seen with a much fuller picture: not a list of differences or difficulties, but a whole person whose experience makes sense when you understand what sits underneath. It echoes the coming-into-focus image that opened Session 2. The facilitator does not need to name this; the room will feel it.

Home and Community

SESSION INTENT

Use the morning's understanding for practical support at home and in the community. Parents and carers look at distress, overwhelm, burnout and School Can't as signs of unmet need and overload, then consider co-regulation, the after-school crash, predictability, interests, outings, siblings and their own capacity, finishing by sharing what works in their own homes.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Describe distress, shutdown and meltdown as responses to overwhelm and unmet need, not choices.
- Recognise Autistic burnout and School Can't as signs of long-term overload.
- Name ways to help in the moment, including reducing input and co-regulation.
- Plan recovery after school and around one community outing.
- Identify one practical idea to try at home, including one that looks after their own capacity.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
12:45 - 12:46	Welcome back from lunch	1	1
12:46 - 12:58	Distress, overwhelm, burnout and School Can't, and what helps in the moment	2-5	12
12:58 - 1:04	Co-regulation and the after-school crash	6-7	6
1:04 - 1:09	Predictability at home and interests	8-9	5
1:09 - 1:16	Planning an outing (table activity)	10	7
1:16 - 1:22	Siblings, family life and your own battery	11-12	6
1:22 - 1:30	Sharing what works and link to Session 5	13	8

PREPARE

- ☐ Participant Workbooks and pens on each table.
- ☐ Tables set for small-group sharing (slides 10 and 13).
- ☐ A visible timer for the 6-minute and 8-minute table activities.
- ☐ Quiet space available: burnout and School Can't may be raised and some parents may need a moment.
- ☐ Information ready on where families can find further support, to give at a break if someone raises a current crisis.



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 4

Home and Community

Home and Community

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

12:45 - 12:46

Welcome participants back from lunch and set the practical focus for the afternoon.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Welcome participants back from lunch.
- 2 Name the shift from understanding Autistic experience this morning to everyday support at home and in the community.
- 3 Explain that the ideas in this session are prompts for family judgement, not a single model of home life.
- 4 Invite participants to take what is workable for their child and family and leave the rest.

KEY MESSAGES

- Home and community supports need to fit the real family.
- A practical plan begins with the child's capacity, preferences and context.

YOU MIGHT SAY

This morning was about understanding. This afternoon is about what that means for everyday life. You know your family best, so take what fits and leave what doesn't.

Thread The afternoon builds on the batteries, spoons and masking content from Session 3.

Distress and unmet needs

What we see is often only the tip of the iceberg.

Behaviour

What we can see and hear.

Underneath

Thoughts and feelings, values, and needs such as belonging, predictability, security and self-expression.

A reaction is rarely a choice. It usually makes sense once we understand what came before: an unexpected change, too much noise, a demand that was too big on that day.

Behaviour is communication. Be curious about what sits underneath.

Distress and unmet needs

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:46 - 12:49

Frame distress as communication about needs: what we see is often only the tip of the iceberg, with thoughts, feelings, values and needs underneath.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the line at the top of the slide: what we see is often only the tip of the iceberg. Then walk through the two cards: behaviour is what we can see and hear; underneath are thoughts and feelings, values, and needs such as belonging, predictability, security and self-expression.
- 2 Give a home example of what might come before a reaction: an unexpected change, too much noise, a demand that was too big on that day.
- 3 Invite participants to think of a recent hard moment and what might have been underneath it. This is private thinking, not sharing.

KEY MESSAGES

- A reaction is rarely a choice. It usually makes sense once we understand what came before.
- Behaviour is communication. Be curious about what sits underneath.

YOU MIGHT SAY

What we see is often only the tip of the iceberg. Underneath are thoughts, feelings and needs we can't see straight away.

When we look back at what came before, a hard moment often starts to make sense. A change of plan, a noisy shop, a request that would be fine on another day.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some families are living with a lot of distress at home right now. Keep the tone free of blame for the child or the parent.
- Link back to the batteries and spoons from Session 3 rather than introducing new theory.

Overwhelm

Shutdown

Turning inward. Freeze or flop. Less able to speak or say what they need. Can be hidden or masked.

Meltdown

Turning outward. Fight or flight. Might look like crying, running away or a big emotional outburst.

These are involuntary responses to overwhelm, not a choice.

Overwhelm

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:49 - 12:52

Describe shutdown and meltdown as involuntary responses to overwhelm.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain shutdown: turning inward. Freeze or flop. Less able to speak or say what they need. It can be hidden or masked.
- 2 Explain meltdown: turning outward. Fight or flight. It might look like crying, running away or a big emotional outburst.
- 3 Point out that a shutdown can be easy to miss, especially if the child is quiet or masking.

KEY MESSAGES

- Shutdowns and meltdowns are involuntary responses to overwhelm, not a choice.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Shutdown and meltdown are both what can happen when a child's system is overwhelmed. One turns inward and one turns outward, and neither is something the child chooses.

A shutdown can be quiet. A child might go still, stop talking or seem to switch off. It can be easy to miss.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid describing meltdowns as tantrums or as something the child can stop on request.
- Parents may recognise hard experiences here. Allow a pause and keep moving gently.

Thread Links to masking in Session 3: a child who masks may shut down rather than melt down, and it may not show until later.

When overwhelm builds up

Autistic burnout

Deep physical, mental and emotional exhaustion after a long time of too much sensory and social demand. Skills and capacity can drop for a while.

School Can't

Not being able to go to school because of overwhelming anxiety, fear or sensory overload. It is not a choice or defiance.

Burnout and School Can't are often signs that a child has been coping with more than we realised, for longer than we realised. Looking underneath helps us find the support, adjustments and recovery they need.

When overwhelm builds up

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:52 - 12:55

Explain Autistic burnout and School Can't as signs of long-term overload, not choice or defiance.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain Autistic burnout: deep physical, mental and emotional exhaustion after a long time of too much sensory and social demand. Skills and capacity can drop for a while.
- 2 Explain School Can't: not being able to go to school because of overwhelming anxiety, fear or sensory overload. It is not a choice or defiance.
- 3 Read the closing line on the slide.

KEY MESSAGES

- Burnout and School Can't are often signs that a child has been coping with more than we realised, for longer than we realised.
- Looking underneath helps us find the support, adjustments and recovery they need.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Sometimes overwhelm doesn't come and go. It builds up over weeks or months.

If your child has lost skills they had, or can't get through the school gate, it is not because they aren't trying. It usually means they have been carrying too much for too long.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some families in the room may be in the middle of burnout or School Can't right now. Acknowledge how hard this is. Do not offer individual advice in the room; offer to talk at a break.
- Avoid 'school refusal' language, which suggests choice.
- Session 5 covers working with school. Point there rather than opening a school discussion now.

What can help in the moment?

Be curious, not judgemental.

Reduce input: fewer words, fewer questions, less noise.

Have a safe, quiet space you have agreed on before.

Remember it is a body response. They are doing the best they can.

Talking it through can wait until they are calm.

What can help in the moment?

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

12:55 - 12:58

WORKBOOK

Workbook - My child's signs and what helps

Give practical ways to respond during overwhelm.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the five points on the slide.
- 2 Emphasise reducing input: fewer words, fewer questions, less noise.
- 3 Explain that a safe, quiet space works best when it has been agreed before, when everyone is calm.
- 4 Remind participants that talking it through can wait until the child is calm.

KEY MESSAGES

- Be curious, not judgemental.
- It is a body response. They are doing the best they can.

YOU MIGHT SAY

In the moment, keep things simple: fewer words, fewer questions, less noise.

The talking can come later. Once your child is calm, that's the time to understand what happened, if they want to.

KEEP IN MIND

- Present these as options, not a script. Parents know what calms their own child.
- Acknowledge that it is hard to stay calm when your child is distressed. That leads into the next slide.

Self-regulation and co-regulation

Co-regulation

A calm, trusted adult helps your child settle. Your steady presence does a lot of the work.

Self-regulation

What your child does to manage their own energy and feelings. It grows over time, with support.

Co-regulation comes first. Self-regulation builds from it.

Self-regulation and co-regulation

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

12:58 - 1:00

Explain co-regulation as the foundation self-regulation grows from.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain co-regulation: a calm, trusted adult helps the child settle. The adult's steady presence does a lot of the work.
- 2 Explain self-regulation: what the child does to manage their own energy and feelings. It grows over time, with support.
- 3 Read the closing line.

KEY MESSAGES

- Co-regulation comes first. Self-regulation builds from it.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Children learn to settle with the help of a calm adult. Your calm presence does a lot of the work, even when you don't say anything.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some parents will hear this as pressure to always be calm. Say plainly that nobody manages this every time.

Thread Your own capacity to co-regulate comes back on slide 12, Your own battery counts.

The after-school crash

Many Autistic children hold it together at school and let go at home.

Recovery first

Food, quiet, movement or screen time, their choice, before any questions or demands.

Talk later

"How was school?" can wait. They may tell you later, often late in the evening, or not at all.

Homework can wait too

Straight after school, the battery is often empty.

Keep it the same

A simple after-school routine they can rely on.

The after-school crash

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

1:00 - 1:04

Help participants recognise the after-school crash and plan recovery as part of the family routine.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Link to masking and the battery from Session 3: many Autistic children hold it together at school and let go at home.
- 2 Walk through the four ideas: recovery first, 'How was school?' can wait, homework can wait too, keep it the same.
- 3 Invite participants to think privately about what changes they notice after school and what helps their child recover.
- 4 Point to "My child's signs and what helps" in the workbook (the "What helps them recover" column) for later.

KEY MESSAGES

- What happens after school can tell us about the load of the day.
- Recovery time can be built into the family routine so it is there every day.
- A softer landing will look different for each child and family.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Many children hold it together all day and let go when they get home. Often that is because home is where they feel safe.

Recovery comes first. Food, quiet, movement or screen time, their choice, before questions or demands. They may tell you about their day later, often at bedtime, or not at all. That is okay.

KEEP IN MIND

- Introduce this as a pattern some families recognise, without assuming it applies to every child.
- Some parents may have been told by school that their child is fine at school. Acknowledge that both can be true.

Thread Builds on 'Masking and the cost of appearing fine' in Session 3. What families see after school can be useful to share with school in Session 5.

Predictability at home

Predictability lowers everyone's load, and home does not need to feel like school.

A few routines

Pick the ones that help your family most: mornings, after school, bedtime.

Visual supports

A schedule on the fridge or a now-and-next card, where they help.

Warnings

Warn before a change or transition, and mean it: "five more minutes".

When plans change

Name it, show it, and give as much warning as you can.

Predictability at home

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:04 - 1:07

Explore predictability that supports the family without making home feel like school.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the opening line: predictability lowers everyone's load, and home does not need to feel like school.
- 2 Walk through the four ideas: a few routines, visual supports, warnings, and what to do when plans change.
- 3 Invite participants to think about which one or two routines would help their family most.

KEY MESSAGES

- Predictability can reduce avoidable uncertainty.
- Routines and visuals should serve the family, not become extra demands.
- Home can remain a place of comfort, relationship and recovery.

YOU MIGHT SAY

You don't need a visual schedule for everything. Pick the parts of the day that are hardest and start there. When you give a warning, mean it. If you say five more minutes, it needs to be five minutes.

KEEP IN MIND

- Present visual supports as optional, used where they help.
- Avoid implying families should run home like a classroom.

Thread Links to visual supports in Session 3.

Interests are an anchor

Regulation

Time with an interest can restore energy faster than almost anything else.

Connection

Their interest is a way in. Connection often starts inside their world.

Joy and identity

Deep interests are part of who they are, not something to ration.

Taking an interest away as a consequence often makes regulation harder.

Interests are an anchor

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

1:07 - 1:09

Position deep interests as sources of regulation, connection and joy.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the three ideas on the slide: regulation, connection, and joy and identity.
- 2 Read the line at the bottom about taking interests away as a consequence.
- 3 Invite participants to think of one of their child's interests and when it helps.

KEY MESSAGES

- Deep interests are part of who a child is, not something to ration.
- Taking an interest away as a consequence often makes regulation harder.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Time with an interest can restore energy faster than almost anything else. It is also a way into your child's world.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid treating interests only as rewards or leverage for compliance.
- Some parents use interest time as a consequence. Acknowledge why, without judgement, and offer the alternative.

Thread Links to deep focus and interests in Session 2.

Planning an outing

A party, the shops, a swimming lesson. What do you already do to plan for it?

- 1 Before: preview it. What, where, how long, and what happens if it is too much?
- 2 During: watch their energy, not the clock. A planned exit is a good plan, not a failure.
- 3 After: plan recovery time.
- 4 Share one idea with your table. Add ideas from others to your workbook.

Planning an outing

SUGGESTED TIME

7 min

CLOCK

1:09 - 1:16

GROUPING

Tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Planning an outing

Practise planning a community outing around load, exits and recovery.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the question on the slide: a party, the shops, a swimming lesson. What do you already do to plan for it?
- 2 Walk through before, during and after.
- 3 Ask each person to choose one real or familiar outing and share one idea with their table.
- 4 Set a timer for 6 minutes.

KEY MESSAGES

- Planning includes what happens before, during and after an outing.
- Planning an exit in advance is a sensible part of the plan.
- Recovery afterwards belongs in the plan.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Choose one outing that's coming up, or one that's hard. Think about before, during and after.

Keep an eye on how they are going rather than the time. Leaving early can still be a successful outing.

ACTIVITY

Table sharing tables · 6 minutes

Choose one outing. What do you already do to plan for it?

- 1 Before: preview it. What, where, how long, and what happens if it is too much?
- 2 During: watch their energy, not the clock. Plan an exit.
- 3 After: plan recovery time.
- 4 Each person shares one idea with the table. Add ideas from others to your workbook.

Bring the room back

- Invite one or two practical examples from the room.

Close: Adjusting, leaving early or recovering afterwards can still be part of a successful outing.

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep the activity practical. The aim is a workable plan, not a perfect outing.
- Some families avoid outings altogether at the moment. That is a valid choice, not a failure.

Siblings and family life

Their own time

Siblings see a lot and carry some. Small, regular one-on-one time helps.

Fair is not the same

Each child gets what they need. It can help to say that out loud.

Words that fit their age

Siblings understand more when they have language for what is going on.

It's okay that it's hard. Balance is something you keep working on.

Siblings and family life

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:16 - 1:19

Acknowledge the needs of the whole family and invite realistic thinking about balance.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the three ideas: their own time, fair is not the same, words that fit their age.
- 2 Read the closing line.
- 3 If participants want to note ideas, "What works in our home" in the workbook includes siblings.

KEY MESSAGES

- Each child gets what they need, and that may look different for each child.
- The aim is a balance the family can sustain, not a perfect arrangement.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Siblings see a lot and carry some. Small, regular one-on-one time can matter more than big outings.

It can help to say out loud: in our family, everyone gets what they need, and that doesn't always look the same.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not offer a formula for fairness or family balance.
- Keep the conversation free from blame and do not ask participants to disclose family conflict.
- Some participants may not have other children, or may be separated or sole carers. Keep examples broad.

Your own battery counts

It helps your child

It is hard to help someone else stay calm when you are running on empty.

Small and daily

Ten minutes, a walk, a cup of tea in peace, asking for help.

Your supports

A partner, family, friends, other parents. The people in this room are one of them.

Looking after yourself is part of looking after your family.

Your own battery counts

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:19 - 1:22

WORKBOOK

Workbook - My own battery

Include parent and carer capacity in family planning.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Connect to the battery from Session 3 and co-regulation on slide 6.
- 2 Walk through the three ideas: it helps your child, small and daily, your supports.
- 3 Invite participants to think quietly about what helps them recharge and what could make this week a little lighter. Point to "My own battery" in the workbook.
- 4 Name the people in the room as one source of support.

KEY MESSAGES

- Looking after yourself is part of looking after your family.
- A small reduction in load is a valid practical action.

YOU MIGHT SAY

It is hard to help someone else stay calm when you are running on empty.

This doesn't have to be big. Ten minutes, a walk, a cup of tea in peace, or asking someone for help.

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep the focus on small, realistic choices rather than idealised self-care.
- Some parents have very little support. Acknowledge this without suggesting they are doing something wrong.
- Looking after your own capacity is practical planning. It says nothing about how much you love your child.

Let's share what works

Families know a lot. Share one thing that works in your home.

- 1 Mornings, after school, outings, bedtime, siblings or your own battery.
- 2 Each person shares one idea with the table.
- 3 Write down one idea you would like to try.

Let's share what works

SUGGESTED TIME

8 min

CLOCK

1:22 - 1:30

GROUPING

Tables

WORKBOOK

Workbook - What works in our home

Draw on the knowledge in the room: each person shares one thing that works at home.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Read the opening line: families know a lot.
- 2 Offer the topics: mornings, after school, outings, bedtime, siblings or your own battery.
- 3 Each person shares one idea with the table. Set a timer for 8 minutes.
- 4 Ask everyone to write down one idea they would like to try.
- 5 To finish, ask participants to keep one thing they notice at home in mind as they move into the next session on partnership with school.

KEY MESSAGES

- Families know a lot. What works in one home can help another.
- What families notice at home can help shape a conversation with school.

YOU MIGHT SAY

You've heard a lot from us today. Now it's your turn. Share one thing that works in your home, big or small.

ACTIVITY

Table sharing tables · 8 minutes

Share one thing that works in your home.

- 1 Choose a topic: mornings, after school, outings, bedtime, siblings or your own battery.
- 2 Each person shares one idea with the table.
- 3 Write down one idea you would like to try.

Close: Keep one home observation in mind for Session 5, Partnership with the School.

KEEP IN MIND

- Sharing is optional. A participant can listen and take ideas.
- Keep the table focused on what works rather than solving one family's situation.

Thread Leads into Session 5: what families notice at home can shape the next conversation with school.

Partnership with the School

SESSION INTENT

Help parents and carers bring their knowledge of their child together with the knowledge held by school staff and support staff, with the child at the centre. Participants look at what makes partnership work, their child's rights at school, how power can shape a meeting, how their child's voice can be included, and they prepare for one purposeful conversation with school.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Describe partnership as family, school staff and support staff working together with the child at the centre.
- Name the key principles of effective collaboration and what makes a school conversation work well.
- Understand, in general terms, the Disability Discrimination Act and the Disability Standards for Education, including the school's duty to consult your child, or you on their behalf, about adjustments.
- Recognise where power can sit in the home-school relationship and some practical ways to balance it.
- Prepare for one purposeful conversation with school, including how their child's voice will be included.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
1:30 - 1:36	Opening and working in partnership	1-3	6
1:36 - 1:42	Effective collaboration and your rights at school	4-5	6
1:42 - 1:51	Power dynamics and activity	6-7	9
1:51 - 1:55	Student voice	8	4
1:55 - 2:03	What works and consultation literacy	9-10	8
2:03 - 2:06	Partnership tools and other supports	11-13	3
2:06 - 2:10	Prepare for a conversation with school	14	4

PREPARE

- ☐ Sticky notes and pens on every table; butcher's paper on the wall headed Home, School and Solutions.
- ☐ Student voice video (Adon) tested with sound, captions on and transcript available.
- ☐ Participant Workbooks open to Session 5 (Power dynamics, Student voice, What works?, Consultation checklist, Prepare for a conversation with school).
- ☐ Copies or a clear view of the Partnership tools shown on slide 11.
- ☐ The NCCD Meetings Tool Kit link (<https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>) and the Department of Education plain-language guides for families.
- ☐ Helpline numbers on slide 13 (Autism Connect, Disability Gateway, Carer Gateway, Lifeline, Kids Helpline) checked as current.
- ☐ A quiet option for participants who find the power discussion difficult.



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 5

Partnership with the School**Partnership with the School**

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

1:30 - 1:31

Open the partnership session and connect it to what families have noticed at home.

WHAT TO DO

- 1** Name the shift from what happens at home to how home and school can understand and act together.
- 2** Ask participants to keep in mind one thing they noticed at home in Session 4 that school might need to know.
- 3** Keep the child at the centre of the conversation.
- 4** Acknowledge that participants will bring very different school experiences, some helpful and some difficult.
- 5** Remind the room that sharing is voluntary, and that schools and staff are not named in the whole group.

KEY MESSAGES

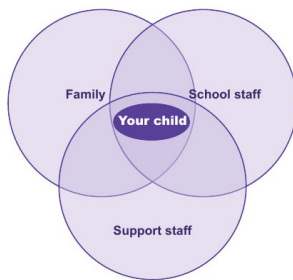
- Partnership is part of understanding and supporting your child, from the start.
- Your child, your family and the school may each hold different parts of the picture.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some families are in a very hard place with their school right now. Acknowledge this without inviting detailed accounts in the whole group.

Thread Picks up what participants noticed at home in Session 4 (Home and Community).

Working in partnership



What is the goal of these intersecting partnerships?

Every partner brings different knowledge and a different relationship with your child.
Your child is at the centre of every partnership.

Working in partnership

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:31 - 1:34

Show where the partnerships around a child intersect, with the child at the centre of every one.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the diagram: family, school staff and support staff, with your child at the centre where they overlap.
- 2 Explain that every partner brings different knowledge and a different relationship with your child and with each other.
- 3 Ask the group: What is the goal of these intersecting partnerships?
- 4 Steer the discussion so the point is made that the child is at the centre of every partnership.
- 5 Ask who else might be part of the picture for their child, such as a therapist, grandparent or out-of-school-hours carer, and how the child's own communication can be included.

KEY MESSAGES

- Positive partnership keeps your child at the centre.
- No single person holds the complete picture.
- Parents and carers bring knowledge of their child that no one else has.

YOU MIGHT SAY

What is the goal of these intersecting partnerships?

KEEP IN MIND

- Use the diagram as a discussion prompt rather than a complete definition.

Thread Draws on 'You are the expert on your child' from Session 1.

Building a home-school partnership

Parents and families are the first and continuing educators of their children

Learning is lifelong and occurs in multiple settings

Partnerships, schools and school communities flourish when the diversity and strengths of families are valued and leveraged

Community engagement expands responsibility and resources

Partnerships grow from mutual trust, respect and responsibility

Partnerships need committed, collaborative and creative leadership

Family-School Partnerships Framework, Department of Education, 2020



Building a home-school partnership

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

1:34 - 1:36

Use the Family-School Partnerships Framework principles to show what families can expect a partnership to look like.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through the six Framework principles briefly.
- 2 Draw attention to the first principle: parents and families are the first and continuing educators of their children.
- 3 Position family knowledge and school knowledge as different, useful perspectives.
- 4 Name what partnership looks like in practice: a shared purpose, respectful listening, your child's voice, clear information, and agreed next steps with follow-up.

KEY MESSAGES

- Your knowledge of your child and the school's knowledge are both needed from the beginning.
- Listening, clarity and shared next steps are things you can look for in practice.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid implying that agreement is needed before listening or respect are possible.

RESOURCES

- Family-School Partnerships Framework - Department of Education, Australian Government - <https://www.education.gov.au/supporting-family-school-community-partnerships-learning/family-school-partnerships/family-school-partnerships-framework>

What is effective collaboration?



What is effective collaboration?

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:36 - 1:39

Name the collaboration principles that strong partnerships share, whoever is at the table.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce why collaboration matters: for an Autistic child there are many people and many points where home and school need to work together.
- 2 Explain that the key collaboration principles are the same across every partnership around your child.
- 3 Ask the group: What are some of the key principles for effective collaboration?
- 4 Build the discussion to cover: shared goals, shared values, mutual trust and respect, consulting on decision-making, seeing other perspectives, inviting curiosity, centring your child's voice and assuming good intent.
- 5 Click to reveal the points on the slide once the room has contributed.

KEY MESSAGES

- The same principles apply in every partnership around your child.
- Assuming good intent and staying curious can help, even when a conversation is hard.

YOU MIGHT SAY

What are some of the key principles for effective collaboration?

How could we work together so school goes well for my child?

KEEP IN MIND

- 'Assume good intent' can be hard to hear for families who have had poor experiences. Acknowledge that trust is built on both sides and is not the family's job alone.

Your rights at school

Disability Discrimination Act 1992

Makes it unlawful to treat someone unfairly because of disability, including in education.

Disability Standards for Education 2005

The school must consult your child, or you on their behalf, about reasonable adjustments, so your child can take part on the same basis as other children.

What you can ask

How will we be consulted? What adjustments are in place? How and when will they be reviewed?

Plain-language guides for families are available from the Department of Education.

Your rights at school

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:39 - 1:42

Give general information about the Disability Discrimination Act and the Disability Standards for Education, and the questions families can ask.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that the Disability Discrimination Act 1992 makes it unlawful to treat someone unfairly because of disability, including in education.
- 2 Explain that under the Disability Standards for Education 2005, the school must consult your child, or you on their behalf, about reasonable adjustments, so your child can take part on the same basis as other children.
- 3 Walk through the three questions families can ask: How will we be consulted? What adjustments are in place? How and when will they be reviewed?
- 4 Point to the plain-language guides for families from the Department of Education.
- 5 State clearly that this is general information, not individual legal advice.

KEY MESSAGES

- The school is required to consult your child, or you on their behalf, about adjustments.
- You can ask how you will be consulted, what adjustments are in place and when they will be reviewed.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not give advice on individual situations or disputes. Point participants to the plain-language guides and the support pathways on slide 13.
- Keep the tone informative rather than adversarial. Knowing your rights supports partnership.

Background The Disability Standards for Education 2005 require schools to consult the student or an associate of the student. Associates include parents and carers, so the school can consult your child directly, you on their behalf, or both.

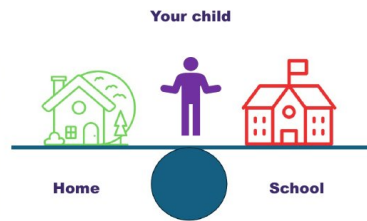
RESOURCES

- Disability Standards for Education 2005 (Cth) - <https://www.legislation.gov.au/Latest/F2005L00767>

Power dynamics

Power can sit in:

- Socio-economic status
- Historical / cultural experiences of education
- Speaking English vs speaking a language other than English
- How school works: teaching approaches, school systems and curriculum
- Perception of the importance / experience of school



Power dynamics

SUGGESTED TIME

3 min

CLOCK

1:42 - 1:45

Help participants notice how agendas, language, authority and decision-making can shape a school conversation.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the seesaw: school, home and your child.
- 2 Name where power can sit: socio-economic status, historical and cultural experiences of education, speaking English or another language, how school works (teaching approaches, school systems and curriculum), and how important school is seen to be.
- 3 Ask the power questions below to look at how meetings work, not to blame anyone.
- 4 Invite participants to think about where school language, timing or process has made it harder for them to take part.

KEY MESSAGES

- Power sits in meeting structures, language and decision pathways, as well as in people.
- Naming an imbalance can help you plan for a more balanced conversation.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Who sets the agenda?

Whose knowledge is heard?

Who can make decisions?

Is your child included in a way that works for them?

What could change about the process?

KEEP IN MIND

- Keep sharing voluntary and avoid detailed complaints about identifiable schools or staff in the whole group.

Power dynamics activity

On sticky notes:

- 1 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a home perspective.
- 2 Write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a school perspective.
- 3 Write how you could address these imbalances.

Share at your table, or add your notes to the wall under Home, School and Solutions.

Power dynamics activity

SUGGESTED TIME

6 min

CLOCK

1:45 - 1:51

GROUPING

Table groups

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Power dynamics

Help participants reflect on real and perceived power imbalances in the home-school relationship, and look for ways to address them.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Make sure every participant has sticky notes and a pen.
- 2 Direct participants to the three instructions on the slide.
- 3 Choose a sharing option that suits the room (see steps).
- 4 Support tables to look for solutions rather than place blame.
- 5 Take feedback from a few participants at the end.

KEY MESSAGES

- Power can be structural, historical, cultural, conscious and unconscious.
- Status can be felt as an imbalance of power, regardless of anyone's intent.

ACTIVITY

Sticky note reflection table groups · 6 minutes

Where do power imbalances sit in the home-school relationship, and how could they be addressed?

- 1 On one sticky note, write an example of an imbalance in power dynamics from a home perspective.
- 2 On a second, write an example from a school perspective.
- 3 On a third, write how you could address these imbalances.
- 4 Option 1: share your notes with your table.
- 5 Option 2: add your notes to the butcher's paper on the wall under Home, School and Solutions.

Bring the room back

- Who sets the agenda?
- Whose knowledge is heard?
- Who can make decisions?
- What could change about the process?

Close: Ask participants to keep one idea from the Solutions column for their conversation plan on slide 14.

KEEP IN MIND

- This may be painful for some participants who have felt powerless in dealings with school. Acknowledge this, and guide the group towards solutions rather than blame.
- Asking for a school perspective is not asking families to excuse poor practice. It helps them plan a conversation that is more likely to work.

Background Educators work inside the culture of education, including shared acronyms such as NAPLAN, NCCD and IEP, which families may not know. Some people naturally give teachers higher status, which can be a cultural or personal attitude. External providers and professionals can also affect the power dynamic around an Autistic child.

Thread The solution chosen here carries into the conversation plan on slide 14 and the Session 6 take-home actions.



Student voice

What decisions were made, and who made them?
What impact did those decisions have on Adon?



Student voice

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

1:51 - 1:55

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Student voice

Show what can happen when a child is not listened to or consulted, and why your child's voice belongs in decisions about them.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the video as an example of a student who is not listened to or consulted.
- 2 Ask participants, while watching, to pay attention to what decisions were made and who made them.
- 3 Play the video.
- 4 Ask the group: What impact did those decisions have on Adon?
- 5 Connect to participants' own children: how are their preferences asked for and heard, at home and at school?

KEY MESSAGES

- Children should have a say in decisions about them, at their level and in the way they communicate.
- Even young children can show preferences: choices offered visually, reactions observed and honoured.
- Ask your child in a way that works for them: What helps? What's hard? What should your teacher know?
- Their answers can go to school in their own words, drawings or choices.
- This is an early step in building self-advocacy.

YOU MIGHT SAY

While watching, pay attention to what decisions were made and who made them.

What impact did those decisions have on Adon?

KEEP IN MIND

- Some parents may recognise their own child's experience in the video. Allow a moment before moving on.

Thread Links to multimodal communication and AAC in Session 3: voice can be spoken, written, drawn, typed or shown.

What works?

Think of a time you worked well with someone at school.
What made it work? What did they do, and what did you do?

What works for everyone at the table:

- Be prepared for meetings
- Share information
- Ask questions
- Seek clarification
- Start from what you both want for your child



What works?

SUGGESTED TIME

6 min

CLOCK

1:55 - 2:01

GROUPING

Small groups

WORKBOOK

Workbook - What works?

Draw on school relationships that have already worked, and name the moves that work for everyone at the table.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to think of a time they worked well with someone at school, such as a teacher, a learning support staff member or a principal.
- 2 Discuss the prompts on the slide in table groups.
- 3 Ask groups to feed back a few key ideas to the whole room.
- 4 Point to the list of what works for everyone at the table and add practical examples of each.

KEY MESSAGES

- Ask for the agenda before the meeting, so you know what to expect.
- You can bring a support person. This is normal and allowed, and it can change the feel of the meeting.
- Bring notes, and ask for notes or minutes to be shared.
- Follow up in writing ('As we agreed...'), so everyone is clear on what was agreed.
- If a meeting went badly, it is fine to ask for a fresh start next time.

YOU MIGHT SAY

What made it work? What did they do, and what did you do?

ACTIVITY

Table reflection small groups · 6 minutes

Think of a time you worked well with someone at school. What made it work? What did they do, and what did you do?

- 1 Think of a time you worked well with someone at school.
- 2 Discuss the prompts at your table.
- 3 Keep examples general and do not name staff or schools.

Bring the room back

- What key ideas came up at your table?

Close: Connect the ideas shared to the list on the slide: be prepared for meetings, share information, ask questions, seek clarification, start from what you both want for your child.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some participants may not have a positive example yet. Invite them to think of any relationship that worked, in or out of school, or to listen and take ideas from others.
- Some families have a hard history with their school, and trust may need rebuilding before anyone can assume the best. Acknowledge this, and keep the focus on what both sides want for the child.

Background Parent and family engagement in learning happens when schools support families to take part in their child's learning in equal partnership with the school. Parents are the experts on their child and an extremely valuable resource (Barker & Harris, 2020).

RESOURCES

- Barker, B., & Harris, D. (2020). Parent and Family Engagement: An Implementation Guide for School Communities. Canberra: ARACY

Consultation literacy

Useful consultation includes:

A clear, shared purpose

Open questions

More than one way to contribute

Respect for your knowledge and your child's

Accurate recording of what was heard

An agreed action, responsibility and follow-up

Ask, listen, and follow up.

Consultation literacy

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

2:01 - 2:03

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Consultation checklist

Show families what useful consultation includes, so they can recognise it and ask for it.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Walk through what useful consultation includes.
- 2 Frame the list as a check families can use before and after a school meeting.
- 3 Make the point: ask, listen, and follow up.

KEY MESSAGES

- Ask, listen, and follow up.
- Useful consultation includes an agreed action, who is responsible and when it will be followed up.

Thread Links back to the Disability Standards for Education on slide 5: consultation is a requirement.

RESOURCES

- Australian Education Research Organisation (2024). Engaging with families of children with disability: Schools practice guide - <https://www.edresearch.edu.au/guides-resources/practice-guides/engaging-families-children-disability-schools-guide>



Partnership tools

Partnership tools

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

2:03 - 2:04

Show the Partnership tools and how families can use them to prepare for and follow up a school meeting.

WHAT TO DO

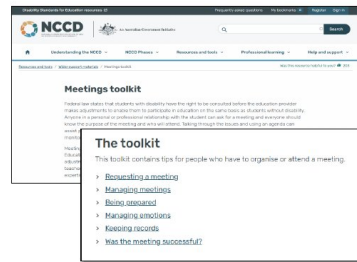
- 1 Show the Partnership tools and briefly explain how each one is used.
- 2 Frame the tools as supports for consultation, not replacements for listening and your child's voice.

KEY MESSAGES

- Tools support a conversation. They do not replace listening and your child's voice.

NCCD Meetings Tool Kit

A free tool kit to help families and schools prepare for meetings about adjustments: before, during and after the meeting.



NCCD Meetings Tool Kit

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

2:04 - 2:05

Introduce the NCCD Meetings Tool Kit as a free resource for families preparing for meetings about adjustments.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain that the Tool Kit helps families and schools prepare for meetings about adjustments: before, during and after the meeting.
- 2 Point families to the Tool Kit on the NCCD website:
<https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>

KEY MESSAGES

- The Tool Kit is free and made for families as well as schools.

KEEP IN MIND

- Do not explain NCCD in detail. If asked, talk about levels of adjustment and point to the official NCCD information.

RESOURCES

- NCCD Meetings Tool Kit - <https://www.nccd.edu.au/wider-support-materials/meetings-toolkit>

Other practical supports

Lifeline
13 11 14
Kids Helpline
1800 55 1800
Also supports parents and carers

Autism Connect

National autism helpline



Other practical supports

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

2:05 - 2:06

Point families to national helplines and support pathways.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Briefly introduce Autism Connect (the national autism helpline), Disability Gateway and Carer Gateway.
- 2 Note that Carer Gateway offers emotional, practical and financial support for carers.
- 3 Point out Lifeline (13 11 14) and Kids Helpline (1800 55 1800). Kids Helpline also supports parents and carers.
- 4 Leave the slide up so participants can note or photograph the numbers.

KEY MESSAGES

- Help is available beyond today, for your child and for you.

KEEP IN MIND

- Check phone numbers and services are current before delivery.

RESOURCES

- Disability Gateway - 1800 643 787
- Carer Gateway - 1800 422 737
- Autism Connect national autism helpline - contact details as shown on the slide
- Lifeline - 13 11 14
- Kids Helpline - 1800 55 1800 (also supports parents and carers)

Prepare for a conversation with school



Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

- What needs to be understood?
- What question will open the conversation?
- How will your child's voice be included?
- What can be decided together?
- How and when will we follow up?

Bring these notes to Session 6.

Prepare for a conversation with school

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

2:06 - 2:10

GROUPING

On your own

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Prepare for a conversation with school

Help each participant prepare for one purposeful conversation with school, to carry into the Session 6 take-home actions.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Ask participants to think of a real or likely conversation with school.
- 2 Invite them to work through the prompts on the slide privately.
- 3 Encourage short notes rather than a full meeting plan.
- 4 Ask participants to carry one idea from the power activity into their plan.
- 5 Keep sharing optional, particularly where the situation is sensitive.

KEY MESSAGES

- Prepare for one purposeful conversation.
- A small, specific next step is enough.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Keep these notes for your conversation plan in Session 6.

ACTIVITY

Private planning on your own · 4 minutes

Prepare for one purposeful conversation.

- 1 What needs to be understood?
- 2 What question will open the conversation?
- 3 How will your child's voice be included?
- 4 What can be decided together?
- 5 How and when will we follow up?

Close: Ask participants to circle the question they will open with and keep these notes for Session 6.

Thread Feeds the second of the three small things in Session 6: one thing you would like school to know, understand or support, and the sentence you will open with.

SESSION

6

2:10 - 2:30 · 20 MINUTES · 7 SLIDES

Full Circle

SESSION INTENT

Bring the day together around the whole child. Participants return to belonging, capacity and joy, choose three small things to take home, find ways to stay connected with other families and Positive Partnerships, give feedback and leave with one small next step.

PARTICIPANTS LEAVE WITH

- Use belonging, capacity and joy to judge whether a change supports their child to flourish.
- Choose one thing to try at home, one thing to share with school and one strength to tell their child this week.
- Know where to find continued connection and learning after the workshop.
- Complete the workshop feedback.

RUN SHEET

Clock	Segment	Slides	Minutes
2:10 - 2:14	Return to the whole child	1-2	4
2:14 - 2:22	Bringing it all together: three small things	3	8
2:22 - 2:25	Connections and resources	4-5	3
2:25 - 2:30	Feedback and farewell	6-7	5

PREPARE

- ☐ Participant Workbooks open to Session 6 (Three small things).
- ☐ Titles and dates for the family webinars and deep dives, once confirmed (slide 4 shows "Titles and dates to confirm").
- ☐ Link and QR code for the online Community of Practice, once available (slide 4 shows "Link and QR code TBA").
- ☐ The feedback link (TBA) and QR code added to slide 6 and tested; paper or verbal alternative available.
- ☐ Local follow-up and contact arrangements confirmed.
- ☐ Protected time: at least 4 minutes for feedback.



Parents and Carers · Primary · Session 6

Full Circle**Full Circle**

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

2:10 - 2:12

Open the final session and return to the child participants described at the start of the day.

WHAT TO DO

- 1** Name this as a short, practical closing session.
- 2** Invite one or two people to look back at the one thing they wanted to know from Session 1 and say what has shifted, or what has been answered. Keep this to 1 to 2 minutes.
- 3** Invite participants to look again at the three things they wrote about their child in Session 1.
- 4** Explain that they will choose a few small actions to carry forward, not a long list.
- 5** Keep the closing grounded rather than adding new content.

KEY MESSAGES

- The day comes back to your child as a whole person.
- One or two small steps are more useful than a long list.

Thread Returns to 'What are some things you love or value about your child?' and the one thing participants wanted to know from Session 1.

Belonging, capacity and joy

Keep all three in the picture.

Belonging

Being recognised,
included and able to
participate as oneself

Capacity

What the day costs,
protects and restores

Joy

Interests, connection and
authentic expression

Return to these when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

Belonging, capacity and joy

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

2:12 - 2:14

Bring the day together through belonging, capacity and joy.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Present belonging, capacity and joy together, as connected ideas.
- 2 Belonging: being recognised, included and able to participate as oneself.
- 3 Capacity: what the day costs, protects and restores.
- 4 Joy: interests, connection and authentic expression.
- 5 Point to the last line on the slide: return to these three when judging whether a change supports flourishing.

KEY MESSAGES

- Belonging, capacity and joy matter as much as getting through the day.
- A change at home or at school can be checked against all three.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Keep all three in the picture.

KEEP IN MIND

- Avoid presenting school results, quiet compliance or doing things alone as the only signs that a child is doing well.

Thread Capacity picks up the batteries, spoons and fluctuating capacity from Session 3 (what costs your child energy and what helps restore it) and your own battery from Session 4; joy picks up interests as an anchor from Session 4.

Bringing it all together

Three small things. Write them in your workbook.

- 1 One thing to try at home this week. Keep it small.
- 2 One thing you would like school to know, understand or support, and the sentence you will open with.
- 3 One strength you see in your child, and a plan to tell them this week.

Bringing it all together

SUGGESTED TIME

8 min

CLOCK

2:14 - 2:22

GROUPING

On your own

WORKBOOK

Workbook - Three small things

Help each participant choose three small, specific actions across home, school and their child's positive identity.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Introduce the three small things on the slide.
- 2 Allow quiet writing time in the Workbook.
- 3 Encourage participants to keep each action small enough to start this week.
- 4 For the school item, point participants back to their notes from Session 5, slide 14.
- 5 Invite one or two people to share if they wish; sharing is optional.

KEY MESSAGES

- A useful action can be small and specific.
- The three prompts connect home, school and your child's positive identity.

ACTIVITY

Individual reflection and action planning on your own · 8 minutes

Three small things. Write them in your workbook.

- 1 One thing to try at home this week. Keep it small.
- 2 One thing you would like school to know, understand or support, and the sentence you will open with.
- 3 One strength you see in your child, and a plan to tell them this week.

Close: Invite participants to keep their notes somewhere they will see them after the workshop.

KEEP IN MIND

- Some families are going through a very hard time. If someone cannot think of an action today, that is fine. Naming a strength may be enough.

Thread Draws together the Session 4 idea to try at home, the Session 5 conversation plan and the Session 1 strengths.

Connections that continue

Each other

The families in this room understand things others may not. Connections made today can last.

Parent groups

Local and online groups, for the questions that come up later.

Webinars and deep dives

Titles and dates to confirm

Online Community of Practice

Link and QR code TBA

Asking for help is part of parenting. You did that by coming today.

Connections that continue

SUGGESTED TIME

2 min

CLOCK

2:22 - 2:24

Point participants towards continued connection with other families, parent groups, family webinars and the online Community of Practice.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Name the four options on the slide: each other, parent groups, webinars and deep dives, and the online Community of Practice.
- 2 Invite participants to swap contact details with others at their table if they would like to.
- 3 Explain how to access the webinars and the Community of Practice.
- 4 Avoid implying that every option will suit every family.
- 5 Read the last line on the slide: asking for help is part of parenting.

KEY MESSAGES

- Connection after today can come through other families, parent groups or online.
- Choose the kind of connection that fits you.

YOU MIGHT SAY

Asking for help is part of parenting. You did that by coming today.

Resources



Resources

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

2:24 - 2:25

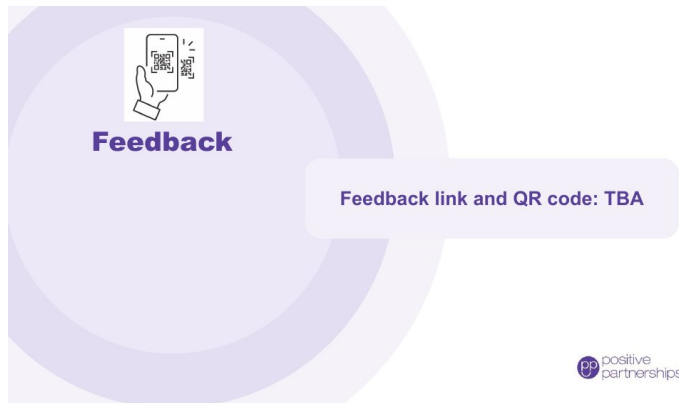
Show where to follow Positive Partnerships online.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Leave the slide up briefly so participants can note or photograph the handles.
- 2 Mention that the website has resources for families on many of today's topics.

RESOURCES

- Positive Partnerships website - positivepartnerships.com.au
- Facebook - facebook.com/PositivePartnershipsAU
- Instagram - [@positivepartnerships](https://www.instagram.com/positivepartnerships)
- Threads - [@positivepartnerships](https://www.threads.net/@positivepartnerships)
- LinkedIn - Positive Partnerships
- Pinterest - pinterest.com.au/PositivePartnershipsAustralia/



Feedback

SUGGESTED TIME

4 min

CLOCK

2:25 - 2:29

Collect participant feedback on the workshop.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Explain why feedback is collected and how it helps shape future workshops for families.
- 2 Show how to access the form, using the feedback link (TBA) and QR code.
- 3 Allow protected time for completion in the room.
- 4 Offer an alternative for anyone who cannot use the online form.

KEEP IN MIND

- The slide shows a placeholder: add the feedback link (TBA) and QR code before delivery.

RESOURCES

- Feedback link and QR code: TBA

Good luck on your journey

Stay curious.
Keep your child at the centre.

Take one small next step, include the people who know your child well and see what happens. Small changes can be adjusted as you go.



Good luck on your journey

SUGGESTED TIME

1 min

CLOCK

2:29 - 2:30

Close warmly and return participants to their child and one small next step.

WHAT TO DO

- 1 Thank participants for their time, their questions and what they shared about their children.
- 2 Invite them to stay curious and keep their child at the centre.
- 3 Remind participants to take their Workbook with their three small things.
- 4 State the follow-up and contact arrangements.

KEY MESSAGES

- Stay curious.
- Keep your child at the centre.
- Take one small next step and include the people who know your child well. Small changes can be adjusted as you go.